YEAR 2 · UNIT 19 · DAYS 687-724

The New Covenant Applied: Acts

Acts 1-28

The Spirit comes. The church is born. The gospel reaches the ends of the earth.

UNIT ANCHOR VERSE

"But you will receive power when the Holy Spirit has come upon you, and you will be my witnesses in Jerusalem and in all Judea and Samaria, and to the end of the earth."

ACTS 1:8

Psalms 2, 16, and 110, which Peter preaches from, and mission psalms (67, 87, 117, 96, 98, 100).

UNIT 19

In this unit

WEEK 99

687	Acts 1:1-26	*Reading*
688	Acts 1:1-11; Hebrews 4:14-16	*Doctrine*
689	John 14:15-31; John 16:5-15; Acts 2:1-21	*Doctrine*
690	Acts 2:37-41; 2 Corinthians 7:8-11	*Doctrine*
691	Acts 2:42; Romans 10:14-17	*Doctrine*
692	Acts 2:1-47	*Reading*
693	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 100

694	Acts 3:1-4:31	*Reading*
695	Acts 4:32-6:7	*Reading*
696	Psalm 2	*Psalm*
697	Psalm 16	*Psalm*
698	Psalm 110:1-7	*Psalm*
699	Acts 6:8-8:3	*Reading*
700	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 101

701	Acts 8:4-40	*Reading*
702	Acts 9:1-43	*Reading*
703	Acts 10:1-11:30	*Reading*
704	Acts 12:1-13:52	*Reading*
705	Psalm 67	*Psalm*
706	Psalm 87	*Psalm*
707	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 102

708	Psalm 117	*Psalm*

709	Acts 14:1-28	*Reading*
710	Acts 15:1-41	*Reading*
711	Acts 16:1-40	*Reading*
712	Acts 17:1-18:28	*Reading*
713	Acts 19:1-41	*Reading*
714	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 103

715	Acts 20:1-38	*Reading*
716	Psalm 96	*Psalm*
717	Psalm 98	*Psalm*
718	Psalm 100	*Psalm*
719	Acts 21:1-22:30	*Reading*
720	Acts 23:1-24:27	*Reading*
721	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 104

722	Acts 25:1-26:32	*Reading*
723	Acts 27:1-28:31	*Reading*
724	Review and Reflection	*Review*

DAY 687 · WEEK 99

Acts 1:1-26

The ascension; choosing Matthias, preparing for power

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Reading · 26 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Acts 1:1-26. Luke picks up where his Gospel ended: Jesus appears alive for forty days, promises the Spirit, and ascends. The disciples wait and pray, and a twelfth apostle is chosen. Notice the commission in verse 8, which is also the outline of the whole book.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Acts is the second volume of Luke's work, addressed again to Theophilus. If the Gospel tells all that Jesus began to do and teach, Acts tells what he continued to do by his Spirit through his church. It covers about thirty years, from the ascension around AD 30 to Paul's imprisonment in Rome around AD 60. Its title, "Acts of the Apostles," is a little misleading. The main actor is the risen Lord, working by the Holy Spirit.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "He presented himself alive to them after his suffering by many proofs, appearing to them during forty days and speaking about the kingdom of God" (1:3).
2. "For John baptized with water, but you will be baptized with the Holy Spirit not many days from now" (1:5).
3. "Lord, will you at this time restore the kingdom to Israel?" (1:6).
4. "But you will receive power when the Holy Spirit has come upon you, and you will be my witnesses in Jerusalem and in all Judea and Samaria, and to the end of the earth" (1:8).
5. "He was lifted up, and a cloud took him out of their sight" (1:9).

6. “This Jesus, who was taken up from you into heaven, will come in the same way as you saw him go into heaven” (1:11).
7. “All these with one accord were devoting themselves to prayer” (1:14).
8. “You, Lord, who know the hearts of all, show which one of these two you have chosen” (1:24).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Luke says that Jesus showed himself alive by “many proofs.” The resurrection was not a vision or a feeling. It was a public fact, and the disciples were eyewitnesses. For forty days he taught them about the kingdom of God. Then he told them not to leave Jerusalem but to wait for the promise of the Father, the baptism with the Holy Spirit.

The disciples ask, “Lord, will you at this time restore the kingdom to Israel?” They are still thinking in terms of a political restoration. Jesus does not rebuke the question, but redirects it. The times are the Father’s business. Their business is to be witnesses, and the power to do it will come from the Spirit. Then comes the outline of Acts: Jerusalem (chapters 1 to 7), Judea and Samaria (8 to 12), and the end of the earth (13 to 28). The gospel will move outward in widening circles.

Then he is lifted up, and a cloud receives him. Two men in white say, “Why do you stand looking into heaven? This Jesus will come in the same way as you saw him go.” The ascension is not an absence. He is enthroned, and he will return. The disciples go back to Jerusalem filled with joy (Luke 24:52), and gather in the upper room with the women, Mary the mother of Jesus, and his brothers. They devote themselves to prayer. This is how a church waits: together, in prayer.

Peter then leads the group to replace Judas. The qualification is that the replacement must have been with them from the baptism of John to the ascension and must be a witness to the resurrection. They propose two men, pray, and cast lots, and the lot falls on Matthias. Christians have differed on whether this was the right choice, since Paul is later called an apostle. But the point is that the Twelve, representing the twelve tribes of renewed Israel, are restored to their number before Pentecost.

STEP 5

Connection

Luke 24:47-53 is the end of Luke’s Gospel, with the same promise and ascension. Joel 2:28-29 promised the Spirit. Ezekiel 36:26-27 and Jeremiah 31:33 promised a new heart and the Spirit within. Psalm 110:1 and Daniel 7:13 are the background to the ascension and the cloud.

Isaiah 49:6 is the light to the ends of the earth. Psalm 69:25 and 109:8 are cited for Judas's replacement. Matthew 28:18-20 is the Great Commission.

STEP 6

Application

Memorize Acts 1:8 this week. It is the memory verse of the unit.

Wait before you act. Spend time in prayer, with others if you can, before an important decision.

Think about your own Jerusalem, Judea, Samaria, and ends of the earth. Who is in each circle for you?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for showing himself alive by many proofs.
- Thank him for the promise of the Spirit.
- Ask him to make you a witness where you are.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 99

"And they devoted themselves to the apostles' teaching and the fellowship, to the breaking of bread and the prayers."

ACTS 2:42

DAY 688 · WEEK 99

Acts 1:1-11; Hebrews 4:14-16

Christ ascended and reigning

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Doctrine · 14 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Acts 1:1-11 slowly, then turn to Hebrews 4:14-16. Today is a doctrinal pause, so you are reading two passages together: Luke's account of Jesus rising into the clouds, and the author of Hebrews telling us what that ascension means for the weak and weary. Ask as you read: where did Jesus go, and what is he doing there now?

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

For forty days after his resurrection, Jesus appeared to his disciples, proving he was alive and teaching them about the kingdom of God. Yesterday's reading closed that season of appearances and opened the book of Acts, which is Luke's second volume. His first volume told what Jesus began to do and teach. Acts tells what he continues to do through his Spirit and his church. But first he must leave. Today we stand on the Mount of Olives with eleven confused men, watching their risen Lord lifted up and taken out of sight. Most Christians celebrate Christmas and Easter. Far fewer know what to do with the ascension. This day exists to correct that, because the ascension is where the story of the resurrection becomes the story of Christ's reign.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Luke calls his Gospel an account of "all that Jesus began to do and teach" (v. 1), which implies that Acts records what Jesus continues to do.
2. Jesus gave "many proofs" that he was alive during forty days (v. 3). The resurrection was physical and public.
3. The disciples ask whether Jesus will now restore the kingdom to Israel (v. 6). They are still thinking in small, national terms.

4. Jesus does not deny the kingdom. He redirects them to the Spirit's power and their witness "to the end of the earth" (vv. 7-8).
5. Jesus is "lifted up" while they are looking, and a cloud takes him from their sight (v. 9).
6. Two men in white tell them Jesus will return "in the same way" as they saw him go (v. 11).
7. Hebrews 4:14 says Jesus "has passed through the heavens." The ascension is described as a journey with a destination.
8. Hebrews 4:15-16 draws a pastoral conclusion: because Jesus sympathizes with weakness, we may draw near to the throne of grace with confidence.

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

The ascension is the event in which the risen Lord Jesus Christ, in his glorified human body, departed from this earth and was received into heaven, where he now sits at the right hand of the Father. It is both a real event on a real day and the beginning of a real, ongoing ministry. The Apostles' Creed confesses it plainly: "He ascended into heaven and is seated at the right hand of God the Father Almighty."

Scripture gives us several truths about the ascension. First, it was bodily. The same Jesus who ate fish with his disciples was taken up. He did not shed his humanity like a costume once the mission was finished. A man now reigns at the right hand of God, and he will remain a man forever. This is astonishing good news for human beings, because it means our nature has been carried into the presence of God and honored there.

Second, the ascension is enthronement. In the ancient world, to sit at the right hand of a king was to share his authority. Psalm 110:1 anticipates it: "The LORD says to my Lord: Sit at my right hand." Peter will preach in Acts 2 that this is exactly what happened to Jesus. Paul says in Ephesians 1:20-22 that God seated Christ above every rule, authority, power, and dominion, and put all things under his feet. The crucified carpenter is Lord of all. This is why the church can speak with confidence in a hostile world: the throne of heaven is not empty or contested. Christ reigns now, even though the full visible evidence of his reign awaits his return.

Third, the ascension inaugurates his priestly intercession. Hebrews insists that Jesus is our great high priest who has passed through the heavens. Under the old covenant, the high priest entered the Most Holy Place once a year with blood, and then he left. Christ has entered the true heavenly sanctuary with his own blood, and he does not need to leave again. Romans 8:34 says he is "at the right hand of God, who indeed is interceding for us." Your Savior is not distant or indifferent. He is your advocate before the Father right now.

Fourth, the ascension makes the gift of the Spirit possible. Jesus told his disciples it was to their advantage that he go away, because if he did not, the Helper would not come (John 16:7). Pentecost is the ascended Christ pouring out his Spirit on his people (Acts 2:33). The church's power in mission is the power of a reigning king.

Fifth, the ascension guarantees a future. The angels said he will come back in the same way. The ascended Christ is also the returning Christ. Between the ascension and the return, the church lives as a people who are sent. We are not left to guard a memory. We are sent to bear witness to a living king.

Some Christians treat the ascension as an awkward epilogue to Easter, as if Jesus got his body back and then needed to be gotten rid of. Scripture treats it as a coronation. The resurrection shows that death is defeated. The ascension shows that the one who defeated it now rules. If the cross is where Christ paid for sin and the resurrection is where he was vindicated, the ascension is where he took his seat, because the work is finished.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Luke opens Acts by looking back and looking forward. Looking back, he reminds Theophilus that his first book dealt with "all that Jesus began to do and teach until the day when he was taken up." The word "began" is important. If the Gospel was only the beginning, then Acts is not the story of what the apostles did but of what the risen Jesus keeps doing, now from heaven, by his Spirit, through his people.

The disciples' question in verse 6 reveals how slowly they understood. They had just spent forty days hearing about the kingdom from the risen Lord, and they still asked if he would restore Israel's national fortunes now. Jesus does not rebuke the hope. He reorders it. The kingdom will come, but the timeline belongs to the Father. In the meantime, they will receive power from the Holy Spirit and be witnesses in Jerusalem, Judea, Samaria, and to the end of the earth. This verse is the outline of the whole book of Acts. The kingdom advances not by political restoration but by the Spirit-empowered testimony of ordinary people.

Then Jesus rises. Luke writes it with restraint. There is no spectacle, no fireworks. He is lifted up, a cloud receives him, and the disciples keep staring at the sky. The cloud is not incidental. Throughout Scripture, a cloud is where God's glory dwells: the pillar in the wilderness, the cloud that filled the tabernacle, the cloud on the mount of transfiguration. Daniel 7:13 sees "one like a son of man" coming with the clouds of heaven to receive an everlasting dominion. The cloud tells the careful reader that Jesus is entering the glory of God, and that Daniel's vision has begun to come true.

The two men in white interrupt the staring. “Why do you stand looking into heaven?” It is a gentle rebuke, and it is also a promise. This same Jesus will come in the same way. The disciples do not need to scan the sky because they have a job to do and a future to expect.

Hebrews 4:14-16 tells us what Jesus is doing in the meantime. “We have a great high priest who has passed through the heavens.” The author is writing to weary believers who were tempted to drift back to the familiar comforts of the old covenant. His answer is to point them upward. The One who went up is a priest, which means he is on your behalf, now, before God. He is not a priest who stands aloof. Verse 15 says he can sympathize with our weaknesses, “one who in every respect has been tempted as we are, yet without sin.” He knows what it is to be tired, hungry, betrayed, and afraid. His ascended glory has not made him forget what it felt like.

Verse 16 is the invitation. “Let us then with confidence draw near to the throne of grace.” Notice the combination of words: throne and grace. A throne suggests authority and judgment. Grace suggests undeserved favor. In the ascension, the two meet. The King who sits on the throne is the one who died for you. When you come before him, you do not find a stern judge reviewing your record but a priest who has already settled it. So you can come with confidence, which does not mean arrogance but boldness, and you will receive mercy for your past and grace for your needs.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 110 is the Old Testament backbone of this day. David writes, “The LORD says to my Lord: Sit at my right hand, until I make your enemies your footstool.” The New Testament quotes this verse more than any other Old Testament text, nearly always about the ascension. Daniel 7 provides the cloud and the Son of Man receiving dominion. Leviticus 16 provides the picture of the high priest entering the Most Holy Place with blood, which Hebrews says Christ has fulfilled. Looking forward, Acts 2 will show Peter explaining Pentecost as the work of the ascended Christ, and Revelation 5 will show the Lamb standing at the center of the throne.

STEP 6

Application

First, let the ascension settle where Jesus is. When life feels out of control, remember that someone is on the throne, and he is the one who loves you. Your circumstances do not outrank his authority.

Second, take your failures and weakness to him without delay. Hebrews says come with confidence. If you have been avoiding prayer because you feel unworthy, you have misunderstood the throne. It is a throne of grace. Tell him exactly what you are struggling with. He has been there.

Third, take comfort that Jesus is praying for you right now. Romans 8:34 says so. On days when you feel you cannot pray, the ascended Christ is already interceding.

Fourth, remember that you have been sent. The disciples were told to stop staring at the sky and start witnessing. Ask God this week to give you one specific opportunity to speak of Christ to someone, and then look for it.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for ascending and sitting at the Father's right hand.

Thank him that he is your king and your high priest.

Ask him to give you confidence to come to his throne of grace.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 99

"And they devoted themselves to the apostles' teaching and the fellowship, to the breaking of bread and the prayers."

ACTS 2:42

DAY 689 · WEEK 99

John 14:15-31; John 16:5-15; Acts 2:1-21

The Person and Work of the Holy Spirit

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read John 14:15-31, John 16:5-15, and Acts 2:1-21. Today is a doctrinal pause on the Holy Spirit: who he is and what he does. Notice what Jesus promised, and what happened at Pentecost.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

On the night before his death, Jesus promised his disciples another Helper. Fifty days after the resurrection, on the Jewish feast of Pentecost, that promise came true. The Spirit had been at work in the Old Testament, hovering over creation, empowering prophets and craftsmen, and anointing kings. But Pentecost marks the beginning of a new stage: the Spirit poured out on all God's people, as the new covenant promised. The church has confessed the Holy Spirit as the third person of the Trinity, equal with the Father and the Son.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "And I will ask the Father, and he will give you another Helper, to be with you forever, even the Spirit of truth" (John 14:16-17).
2. "But the Helper, the Holy Spirit, whom the Father will send in my name, he will teach you all things and bring to your remembrance all that I have said to you" (John 14:26).
3. "And when he comes, he will convict the world concerning sin and righteousness and judgment" (John 16:8).
4. "When the Spirit of truth comes, he will guide you into all the truth" (John 16:13).
5. "He will glorify me, for he will take what is mine and declare it to you" (John 16:14).

6. “And suddenly there came from heaven a sound like a mighty rushing wind, and it filled the entire house where they were sitting” (Acts 2:2).

7. “And they were all filled with the Holy Spirit and began to speak in other tongues as the Spirit gave them utterance” (Acts 2:4).

8. “And in the last days it shall be, God declares, that I will pour out my Spirit on all flesh” (Acts 2:17).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

The Holy Spirit is the third person of the Trinity: fully God, one in being with the Father and the Son, yet distinct as a person. Jesus calls him “he” and “the Helper” (the Greek word, paraclete, means one called alongside to help, advocate, or comfort). The Bible gives the Spirit divine attributes (eternal, all-knowing, present everywhere) and divine works (creation, inspiration of Scripture, new birth). His work in salvation is to apply what Christ has accomplished. He convicts of sin, gives new birth, unites believers to Christ, dwells within them, seals them, sanctifies them, gives gifts for the building up of the church, and assures them that they are God’s children. His ministry is Christ-centered: Jesus said, “He will glorify me.” At Pentecost, the Spirit was poured out on all believers, not just prophets and kings, as Joel foretold. Every Christian has the Spirit (Romans 8:9), and every Christian is called to be filled with him continually (Ephesians 5:18). Christians differ on the nature of some gifts, such as tongues and healing, and on whether the experience called the baptism or filling of the Spirit is distinct from conversion. All agree that without the Spirit there is no new life, no understanding of Scripture, and no power for witness.

STEP 4

Interpretation

In the Upper Room, Jesus tells his troubled disciples that he is leaving, but they will not be left as orphans. He will ask the Father, and the Father will give “another Helper.” The word “another” means another of the same kind. The Spirit will be to them what Jesus has been. And he will be with them forever. He is called the Spirit of truth. He will dwell with them and in them. He will teach them and remind them of what Jesus said. This is the promise behind the New Testament: the Spirit would help the apostles to remember and understand what Jesus taught, and so give us the Scriptures.

In chapter 16, Jesus says it is to their advantage that he goes away, for the Helper will not come otherwise. The Spirit’s work in the world is to convict: of sin, because they do not believe in Jesus; of righteousness, because Jesus goes to the Father and the world no longer

sees him; and of judgment, because the ruler of this world is judged. His work with believers is to guide them into all truth, and above all to glorify Christ. He does not speak on his own authority. A mark of the Spirit's presence is that Jesus is exalted.

Then on the day of Pentecost, the promise comes. A sound like a rushing wind fills the house. Tongues like flames rest on each of them. They are all filled with the Holy Spirit and speak in other languages, so that visitors from many nations each hear "the mighty works of God" in their own tongue. Some mock, saying they are drunk. Peter stands and quotes Joel: "In the last days, I will pour out my Spirit on all flesh, and your sons and daughters shall prophesy." The reversal of Babel has begun. At Babel languages were confused and people scattered. At Pentecost, languages are understood and people gathered. The Spirit comes on young and old, men and women, slave and free, so that the whole people of God can know him. This is the new covenant: not a few prophets but a kingdom of prophets.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 1:2 and Psalm 104:30 show the Spirit in creation. Numbers 11:29 has Moses wishing all the LORD's people were prophets. Ezekiel 36:26-27 and Jeremiah 31:33-34 promised the Spirit in the new covenant. Joel 2:28-32 is Peter's text. Genesis 11:1-9 is Babel. Romans 8:9-16 describes the Spirit in the believer. Ephesians 1:13-14 and 5:18 speak of the seal and the filling. Galatians 5:22-23 lists the fruit of the Spirit. 1 Corinthians 12 to 14 treat gifts.

STEP 6

Application

Thank the Father for the Spirit by name, and ask him to fill you today.

Notice where Jesus is being glorified in your life, a sign of the Spirit's work.

Ask the Spirit to open your Bible as you read, as Jesus promised.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank the Father for sending the Spirit to be with you forever.
- Ask the Spirit to teach you, convict you, and remind you of Jesus.
- Tell him where you need his help today.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 99

“And they devoted themselves to the apostles’ teaching and the fellowship, to the breaking of bread and the prayers.”

ACTS 2:42

DAY 690 · WEEK 99

Acts 2:37-41; 2 Corinthians 7:8-11

Turning from sin to God

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Doctrine · 9 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Acts 2:37-41 and 2 Corinthians 7:8-11. Today is a doctrinal pause on repentance, turning from sin to God. Notice what Peter says after his sermon, and how Paul distinguishes two kinds of grief.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Peter has just preached the first Christian sermon, and the crowd has been told that they crucified the Messiah. Their question is the most important question: what shall we do? Peter's answer begins with repentance. In 2 Corinthians, Paul writes to a church he had grieved with a stern letter, and he rejoices at the result, not because they were hurt, but because the hurt led to repentance.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Now when they heard this they were cut to the heart, and said to Peter and the rest of the apostles, Brothers, what shall we do?" (Acts 2:37).
2. "Repent and be baptized every one of you in the name of Jesus Christ for the forgiveness of your sins, and you will receive the gift of the Holy Spirit" (Acts 2:38).
3. "For the promise is for you and for your children and for all who are far off, everyone whom the Lord our God calls to himself" (Acts 2:39).
4. "So those who received his word were baptized, and there were added that day about three thousand souls" (Acts 2:41).
5. "As it is, I rejoice, not because you were grieved, but because you were grieved into repenting" (2 Corinthians 7:9).

6. “For godly grief produces a repentance that leads to salvation without regret” (2 Corinthians 7:10).
7. “Whereas worldly grief produces death” (2 Corinthians 7:10).
8. “For see what earnestness this godly grief has produced in you” (2 Corinthians 7:11).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

Repentance is a change of mind and heart about sin and God that results in a change of direction. It includes three elements: recognizing sin for what it is, being sorry for it (not just for its consequences but because it offends God), and turning from it to God, with a purpose to obey. Repentance and faith are two sides of one turning: repentance turns from sin and faith turns to Christ. Jesus began his ministry by calling for both (Mark 1:15). Repentance is a gift of God (Acts 11:18, 2 Timothy 2:25), not a work that earns forgiveness, and it is a lifelong habit, not a one-time act. As Luther put it, the whole life of believers should be repentance. The Bible distinguishes godly grief from worldly grief. Worldly grief is sorrow over being caught or over the damage done to oneself. It can lead to bitterness or despair, as with Judas. Godly grief is sorrow over having sinned against God, and it moves us toward him. It leads to confession, change, and joy. Repentance does not bring forgiveness by its own merit. Forgiveness is on the basis of Christ’s death, received by faith. But there is no saving faith without repentance.

STEP 4

Interpretation

The crowd at Pentecost is “cut to the heart.” The Spirit has convicted them, as Jesus promised. They do not argue or defend themselves. They ask, “What shall we do?” Peter replies, “Repent and be baptized.” Repentance is first. It involves a change of mind about who Jesus is: the one they crucified is Lord and Christ. It involves a change of heart toward sin. Then comes baptism, the outward sign of entering the Christian community and being cleansed. The promise is the forgiveness of sins and the gift of the Holy Spirit. And the promise is for them, for their children, and for all who are far off, whom the Lord calls. Peter urges, “Save yourselves from this crooked generation.” About three thousand were added that day.

Paul’s letter to the Corinthians draws a vital distinction. Earlier he had sent a painful letter. He is glad, not because it hurt them, but because their pain led somewhere. “Godly grief produces a repentance that leads to salvation without regret, whereas worldly grief produces death.” Compare Peter, who wept bitterly and was restored, with Judas, who was remorseful but went away and hanged himself. Both felt sorrow. Peter’s sorrow brought him back to Christ. Judas’s sorrow turned inward and ended in despair.

Then Paul lists the fruit of true repentance: earnestness, eagerness to clear themselves, indignation, fear, longing, zeal, and a readiness to see justice done. Repentance is not just a feeling. It makes a difference in how we live. A genuinely repentant person wants to make things right.

For the new believer, repentance can feel frightening, as though God is looking for a reason to condemn. In fact, repentance is a gift. God leads us to it by his kindness (Romans 2:4). When you see your sin, it is the Spirit at work. And the way to the Father is always open: "If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness" (1 John 1:9).

STEP 5

Connection

Mark 1:15 and Luke 24:47 call for repentance. Psalm 51 is David's great prayer of repentance. Joel 2:12-13 calls for returning to the LORD with the whole heart. Luke 15:17-24 is the prodigal's repentance. Matthew 26:75 and 27:3-5 contrast Peter and Judas. Romans 2:4 says God's kindness leads to repentance. 1 John 1:9 promises forgiveness. Revelation 2:5 calls churches to repent.

STEP 6

Application

Pray Psalm 51 slowly, and name any sin you need to turn from.

Ask yourself: is my grief over sin godly or worldly? Does it move me toward God or away?

Make a concrete change this week as the fruit of repentance, such as an apology, a restitution, or a broken habit.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for the gift of repentance.
- Ask him to give you godly grief that leads to life.
- Confess a sin and turn from it, in your own words.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 99

“And they devoted themselves to the apostles’ teaching and the fellowship, to the breaking of bread and the prayers.”

ACTS 2:42

DAY 691 · WEEK 99

Acts 2:42; Romans 10:14-17

The Means of Grace, Word, Sacrament, Prayer

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Acts 2:42 and Romans 10:14-17. Today is a doctrinal pause on the means of grace: the ordinary ways God works in his people. Notice the four things the first church devoted itself to, and how Paul explains that faith comes by hearing.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After three thousand are added to the church at Pentecost, Luke gives a one-verse summary of what they did together. Paul, in Romans 10, explains why preaching is essential: no one can call on a Lord they have not heard about. The church has long called the means by which God gives and increases grace "the means of grace". The Reformers summarized them as the Word, the sacraments (baptism and the Lord's Supper), and prayer.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "And they devoted themselves to the apostles" teaching and the fellowship' (Acts 2:42).
2. "To the breaking of bread and the prayers" (Acts 2:42).
3. "For everyone who calls on the name of the Lord will be saved" (Romans 10:13).
4. "How then will they call on him in whom they have not believed? And how are they to believe in him of whom they have never heard?" (Romans 10:14).
5. "And how are they to hear without someone preaching?" (Romans 10:14).
6. "And how are they to preach unless they are sent?" (Romans 10:15).
7. "How beautiful are the feet of those who preach the good news!" (Romans 10:15).
8. "So faith comes from hearing, and hearing through the word of Christ" (Romans 10:17).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

The means of grace are the ordinary channels through which God gives his people his blessing, strengthens their faith, and conforms them to Christ. They are not magic, and they do not work apart from faith and the Holy Spirit. But God has promised to use them. The Reformed tradition names three main means: the Word, the sacraments, and prayer. The Word, read and preached, is the primary means. “Faith comes from hearing” (Romans 10:17). The Spirit uses the Scriptures to convict, to convert, and to sanctify. The sacraments are the signs and seals of the gospel, instituted by Christ: baptism, which marks entrance into the covenant community, and the Lord’s Supper, in which believers feed on Christ by faith. Christians differ on how Christ is present in the Supper and on who should be baptized, but all agree that these are gifts to be received with faith. Prayer is the response to God’s Word and the believer’s way of seeking him. To these, Acts 2:42 adds fellowship, the life together in which believers encourage and build up one another. The means of grace are meant to be practiced in the context of a local church. They remind us that the Christian life is not a solo project. God gives grace through a people, a book, a meal, and a prayer.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Acts 2:42 is a short portrait of a healthy church. They “devoted themselves,” a word that means persistent, steadfast commitment. They did not drop in occasionally. First, “the apostles” teaching.’ The church was built on the teaching of those who had been with Jesus, now preserved in the New Testament. Second, “the fellowship,” the sharing of life, resources, and burdens that grows out of a shared faith. Third, “the breaking of bread,” which likely includes shared meals and the Lord’s Supper. Fourth, “the prayers,” both private and corporate.

Notice that these are ordinary things. There is no mention of a new program or a special technique. God works through ordinary means: teaching, fellowship, meals, and prayer. This is encouraging. You do not need extraordinary experiences to grow. You need to be steadily present in these four things.

Romans 10 makes the case for why the Word matters so much. Paul builds a chain of questions. People cannot call on the Lord unless they believe. They cannot believe unless they have heard. They cannot hear unless someone preaches. They cannot preach unless they are sent. So salvation depends on the proclamation of the gospel. “How beautiful are the feet of those who preach the good news!” Then the summary: “Faith comes from hearing, and hearing through the word of Christ.” The word is not a mere pointer to something else. The Spirit works through it.

This is why time in the Word matters. You are putting yourself under the Word. It is also the reason that gathering with a church matters. You hear the Word preached, you pray with others, and you receive the sacraments. These are not extras. They are how God has chosen to feed his people.

STEP 5

Connection

Deuteronomy 8:3 says man lives by every word from the mouth of God. Isaiah 55:10-11 says God's word accomplishes his purpose. Matthew 28:19-20 commands baptism and teaching. Luke 22:19 and 1 Corinthians 11:23-26 institute the Lord's Supper. Hebrews 10:24-25 calls us not to neglect meeting together. Colossians 3:16 says to let the word of Christ dwell richly. 1 Peter 2:2 says to long for the pure spiritual milk. Ephesians 4:11-16 describes the building up of the church.

STEP 6

Application

Evaluate your own pattern against the four: teaching, fellowship, bread, prayer. Which is weakest?

Commit to regular attendance at your church. Treat it as a means of grace, not an option.

Thank someone who first brought you the gospel. Their feet were beautiful.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the ordinary means of grace: his Word, the sacraments, and prayer.

Ask him to make you faithful in using them.

Ask him to meet you through them.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 99

"And they devoted themselves to the apostles' teaching and the fellowship, to the breaking of bread and the prayers."

ACTS 2:42

DAY 692 · WEEK 99

Acts 2:1-47

Pentecost, the Spirit poured on all flesh

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Reading · 47 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Acts 2:1-47. The Spirit falls on Pentecost, Peter preaches the first Christian sermon, three thousand repent, and the new community forms. You have already studied the Spirit and repentance in doctrinal pauses. Today, read the narrative as a whole.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Pentecost, fifty days after Passover, was one of three pilgrim feasts. Jerusalem was crowded with Jews from across the Roman world. The disciples were gathered together when the Spirit came. Peter's sermon is a model of apostolic preaching: it explains the event from the Scriptures, proclaims the death and resurrection of Jesus, and calls for repentance.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "When the day of Pentecost arrived, they were all together in one place" (2:1).
2. "We hear them telling in our own tongues the mighty works of God" (2:11).
3. "And it shall come to pass that everyone who calls upon the name of the Lord shall be saved" (2:21).
4. "This Jesus, delivered up according to the definite plan and foreknowledge of God, you crucified and killed by the hands of lawless men" (2:23).
5. "Being therefore exalted at the right hand of God, and having received from the Father the promise of the Holy Spirit, he has poured out this that you yourselves are seeing and hearing" (2:33).
6. "Let all the house of Israel therefore know for certain that God has made him both Lord and Christ, this Jesus whom you crucified" (2:36).

7. “And all who believed were together and had all things in common” (2:44).
8. “Praising God and having favor with all the people. And the Lord added to their number day by day those who were being saved” (2:47).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The Spirit comes on the disciples as promised. The visitors from many nations are amazed to hear the apostles speaking about the mighty works of God in their own languages. Some are perplexed, and others mock. Peter stands with the eleven and explains: this is what was spoken by the prophet Joel. In the last days, God will pour out his Spirit on all flesh. The day of the LORD has begun.

Peter then preaches Christ. Jesus of Nazareth was a man attested by God with mighty works, wonders, and signs. He was delivered up by the definite plan and foreknowledge of God, and killed by lawless men. Both are true: God’s plan and human guilt. But God raised him up, because it was not possible for death to hold him. Peter cites Psalm 16: David spoke of the resurrection of the Christ. David died and his tomb is here, but David was a prophet, and he spoke of one of his descendants. Peter then cites Psalm 110: “The Lord said to my Lord, Sit at my right hand.” Jesus is exalted, and from the right hand he has poured out the Spirit. “Let all the house of Israel therefore know for certain that God has made him both Lord and Christ.”

The result is conviction. Peter calls them to repent and be baptized, and about three thousand are added. Then Luke gives a picture of the new community. They devote themselves to the apostles’ teaching, fellowship, the breaking of bread, and prayer. Awe comes on every soul, and many wonders and signs are done by the apostles. They have all things in common, selling possessions to give to anyone in need. Day by day they attend the temple together and break bread in their homes with glad and generous hearts. They have favor with all the people, and the Lord adds to their number daily those who are being saved.

This is the birth of the church. It is not a human organization but a work of the Spirit, centered on the risen Christ. Its marks are Word, fellowship, sacrament, prayer, generosity, joy, and evangelism.

STEP 5

Connection

Joel 2:28-32 is the prophecy fulfilled. Psalm 16:8-11 and Psalm 110:1 are Peter’s texts. Leviticus 23:15-22 describes the Feast of Weeks. Exodus 19 and 20 recall the giving of the law at Sinai, as Pentecost came to be associated with it. Genesis 11 is Babel. Ezekiel 36:26-27 and Jeremiah 31:33 fit the new covenant. Romans 8:9 and Ephesians 2:19-22 describe the Spirit and the church. 1 John 3:17-18 teaches generosity.

STEP 6

Application

Read the sermon (2:14-41) aloud. Notice how Peter uses Scripture and then calls for a response.

Which of the marks of the early church would you like to see more in your own church? Pray for it.

Share something with someone in need this week, as the first believers did.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for pouring out the Spirit on his people.

Tell him what it means that he is both Lord and Christ.

Ask him to fill you with his Spirit.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 99

"And they devoted themselves to the apostles' teaching and the fellowship, to the breaking of bread and the prayers."

ACTS 2:42

DAY 693 · WEEK 99

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Acts 2:42 slowly, several times, and say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"And they devoted themselves to the apostles' teaching and the fellowship, to the breaking of bread and the prayers."

ACTS 2:42

REST

Meditation

Luke gives this single verse as a portrait of the first church after Pentecost. It is a pattern for every church that follows.

"They devoted themselves." The verb means to persist, to be strongly committed. It was not casual. These believers made time for each other and for the means of grace.

"To the apostles" teaching.' Their life was built on the teaching handed down from Jesus through his apostles. Today we have that teaching in the New Testament. A healthy church listens to Scripture.

"And the fellowship." The Greek word is koinonia, sharing in common. The church is a family, bound by the same Lord and the same Spirit, sharing life and burdens.

"The breaking of bread." This includes common meals and the Lord's Supper, where believers remember Jesus' death and feed on him by faith.

“And the prayers.” They prayed together, often and earnestly. The church began with prayer and moved forward in prayer.

When you wonder what the Christian life should look like, say this verse. It is simple, and it is enough to start.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you began Acts with the risen Jesus’ promise: “You will receive power when the Holy Spirit has come upon you, and you will be my witnesses.” Your first doctrinal pause was on Christ’s ascension, reigning and interceding. Then you studied the person of the Holy Spirit, and saw Jesus’ promise of a Helper fulfilled at Pentecost. A pause on repentance showed you the difference between godly grief and worldly grief. Another on the means of grace showed you the ordinary ways God feeds his people: Word, sacrament, prayer, and fellowship. In Acts 2 you read Peter’s first sermon, heard three thousand respond, and saw the birth of the church.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Jesus ascended and now reigns at the Father’s right hand. How does knowing that he is on the throne and interceding for you change the way you face this week?

Peter’s hearers were cut to the heart and asked, “What shall we do?” When have you been cut to the heart by the Spirit? How did you respond?

Of the four things the first church devoted itself to (teaching, fellowship, breaking of bread, prayers), which do you most need to grow in?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for ascending and pouring out the Spirit.

Thank him for the church built at Pentecost.

Rest in him.

DAY 694 · WEEK 100

Acts 3:1-4:31

Healing at the gate; preaching; opposition begins

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Reading · 62 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Acts 3:1-4:31. Peter and John heal a lame man at the temple gate, Peter preaches, and the apostles are arrested. They answer the council with bold words, and the church prays for boldness. Notice how Peter ties everything to Jesus' name.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Peter and John go up to the temple at the hour of prayer, three in the afternoon. At the Beautiful Gate, a man lame from birth is carried every day to beg. What follows is the first public miracle in Acts, and it leads to the first conflict with the authorities. The same leaders who condemned Jesus now face his disciples.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I have no silver and gold, but what I do have I give to you. In the name of Jesus Christ of Nazareth, rise up and walk!" (3:6).
2. "And you killed the Author of life, whom God raised from the dead" (3:15).
3. "Repent therefore, and turn back, that your sins may be blotted out" (3:19).
4. "You are the sons of the prophets and of the covenant that God made with your fathers, saying to Abraham, And in your offspring shall all the families of the earth be blessed" (3:25).
5. "And there is salvation in no one else, for there is no other name under heaven given among men by which we must be saved" (4:12).
6. "Now when they saw the boldness of Peter and John, and perceived that they were uneducated, common men, they were astonished. And they recognized that they had

been with Jesus" (4:13).

7. "For we cannot but speak of what we have seen and heard" (4:20).

8. "And when they had prayed, the place in which they were gathered together was shaken, and they were all filled with the Holy Spirit and continued to speak the word of God with boldness" (4:31).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The lame man expects money. Peter says, "I have no silver and gold, but what I do have I give to you." What the church has is far greater: the name of Jesus Christ of Nazareth. The man leaps up and enters the temple walking and leaping and praising God. The crowd gathers in amazement, and Peter preaches.

His sermon makes three points. First, don't look at us; the power is Jesus'. God has glorified his servant Jesus, whom you denied and killed, the Author of life, whom God raised. Second, you acted in ignorance, but God used it to fulfill what the prophets said about the Christ's suffering. Third, repent and turn back, that your sins may be blotted out, that times of refreshing may come from the Lord. And he reminds them that they are heirs of the covenant with Abraham: in your offspring all the families of the earth shall be blessed. God raised up his servant and sent him to you first, to bless you by turning every one of you from your wickedness. The Abrahamic promise is the framework for the mission.

The priests and the captain of the temple guard arrest them. But many who heard believed, and the number of men grew to about five thousand. The next day, before the same council that condemned Jesus, Peter, filled with the Holy Spirit, speaks of the rejected stone (Psalm 118): "There is salvation in no other name." This is a bold claim of Jesus' exclusivity. The council marvels at the confidence of "uneducated, common men" and recognizes that they had been with Jesus. With the healed man standing beside them, they have nothing to say. They warn them to stop speaking in this name. Peter and John answer: "Whether it is right in the sight of God to listen to you rather than to God, you must judge, for we cannot but speak of what we have seen and heard."

When released, they go to their friends, and the whole church prays. They do not ask for safety. They quote Psalm 2 (which you read in a few days) and pray for boldness. The place is shaken, and they are all filled with the Spirit and speak the word of God with boldness.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 52:13 and 53:11 speak of God's servant. Deuteronomy 18:15 is the prophet like Moses. Genesis 12:3 and 22:18 are the Abrahamic promise. Psalm 118:22 is the stone. Psalm 2:1-2 is quoted in Acts 4:25-26. Philippians 2:9-11 says God gave him the name above every name. John 14:6 says no one comes to the Father except through him. Hebrews 13:15 calls us to continually offer a sacrifice of praise.

STEP 6

Application

Ask what you have to give that is better than silver and gold. Give it to someone this week.

When you are afraid to speak about Jesus, pray the church's prayer: not for safety, but for boldness.

Let people take note that you have been with Jesus. How?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus that there is no other name by which we must be saved.
- Ask him to make you bold.
- Tell him what you would say to someone about him today.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 100

"And there is salvation in no one else, for there is no other name under heaven given among men by which we must be saved."

ACTS 4:12

DAY 695 · WEEK 100

Acts 4:32-6:7

Sharing; Ananias and Sapphira; the Seven appointed

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Reading · 49 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Acts 4:32-6:7. The church shares everything, Barnabas gives, Ananias and Sapphira lie to the Spirit, the apostles are arrested again, and seven men are chosen to serve. Notice the contrast between the true generosity and the false.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The young church is growing rapidly under pressure from outside and now faces problems from inside. In these chapters, we see its generosity, the danger of hypocrisy, further persecution, and an organizational crisis over the care of widows. In each, the church responds in a way that preserves its witness.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Now the full number of those who believed were of one heart and soul, and no one said that any of the things that belonged to him was his own, but they had everything in common” (4:32).
2. “There was not a needy person among them” (4:34).
3. “Ananias, why has Satan filled your heart to lie to the Holy Spirit and to keep back for yourself part of the proceeds of the land?” (5:3).
4. “And great fear came upon the whole church and upon all who heard of these things” (5:11).
5. “We must obey God rather than men” (5:29).
6. “Then they left the presence of the council, rejoicing that they were counted worthy to suffer dishonor for the name” (5:41).

7. “Therefore, brothers, pick out from among you seven men of good repute, full of the Spirit and of wisdom, whom we will appoint to this duty” (6:3).

8. “And the word of God continued to increase, and the number of the disciples multiplied greatly in Jerusalem” (6:7).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The church was of one heart and soul. The believers sold property and laid the proceeds at the apostles’ feet to be distributed to those in need. This was voluntary, not compulsory, and a spontaneous overflow of love. Barnabas, whose name means “son of encouragement,” sold a field and gave the money.

Ananias and Sapphira did the same, but they kept back part and pretended to give all. Peter says, “You have not lied to man but to God.” Both fall dead. The sin was not keeping part of the money. Peter says the land was theirs to keep. The sin was hypocrisy: pretending to be more generous than they were, to gain a reputation. Luke says great fear came on the whole church. God takes the purity of his church seriously.

The apostles continue to do signs, and the sick are brought into the streets. The high priest and the Sadducees are filled with jealousy and arrest them, but an angel opens the prison doors at night and tells them to go and preach. When they are brought before the council, they say: “We must obey God rather than men.” Peter again preaches Jesus, crucified and raised, to give repentance and forgiveness. The council wants to kill them, but Gamaliel, a respected teacher of the law, advises caution: if this is from men, it will fail; if it is from God, you cannot overthrow it. They flog the apostles and charge them not to speak in Jesus’ name. The apostles leave “rejoicing that they were counted worthy to suffer dishonor for the name.”

Then comes an internal problem. The Greek-speaking widows are being overlooked in the daily distribution. The apostles do not dismiss the complaint. They gather the disciples and propose that seven men be chosen to oversee this ministry, so that the apostles can devote themselves to prayer and the ministry of the word. The seven all have Greek names, suggesting they were from the complaining group. The church chooses them, the apostles pray and lay hands on them, “and the word of God continued to increase.” Stephen and Philip are among them. The church solves a problem by creating a ministry of service, a model for the later office of deacon.

STEP 5

Connection

Deuteronomy 15:4 said there should be no poor among you if you obey. Joshua 7 is the story of Achan's hidden sin, with a similar severity. Proverbs 21:3 says to do righteousness and justice. Matthew 6:1-4 warns against giving to be seen. Galatians 6:2 says to bear one another's burdens. 1 Timothy 3:8-13 describes deacons. James 1:27 speaks of caring for widows. 2 Corinthians 9:7 says God loves a cheerful giver.

STEP 6

Application

Examine your own giving. Is it done for God or for a reputation? Give something in secret.

Pray for your church's leaders, that they would devote themselves to prayer and the Word.

Where is someone being overlooked in your church? What could you do?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for the generosity of the early church.
- Ask him to keep you from hypocrisy.
- Ask him to teach you to give from a sincere heart.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 100

"And there is salvation in no one else, for there is no other name under heaven given among men by which we must be saved."

ACTS 4:12

DAY 696 · WEEK 100

Psalm 2

The nations rage, Peter's Pentecost proclamation

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Psalm · 12 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 2. The nations plot against the LORD and his Anointed, but the LORD installs his King. You met this psalm earlier in the plan; today read it through Acts 4, where the church prays it after the first arrests.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 2 was a coronation psalm, sung when a king of David's line took the throne. In the New Testament it is quoted as speaking of Jesus, the ultimate Anointed One. In Acts 4:25-26, the believers quote verses 1 and 2 as they pray after the arrest of Peter and John. They see Herod, Pilate, the nations, and the peoples of Israel as the fulfillment of the rage. Their confidence is that the one enthroned in heaven laughs.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Why do the nations rage and the peoples plot in vain?" (v. 1).
2. "The kings of the earth set themselves, and the rulers take counsel together, against the LORD and against his Anointed" (v. 2).
3. "He who sits in the heavens laughs; the Lord holds them in derision" (v. 4).
4. "As for me, I have set my King on Zion, my holy hill" (v. 6).
5. "I will tell of the decree: The LORD said to me, You are my Son; today I have begotten you" (v. 7).
6. "Ask of me, and I will make the nations your heritage, and the ends of the earth your possession" (v. 8).
7. "Now therefore, O kings, be wise; be warned, O rulers of the earth" (v. 10).

8 “Kiss the Son, lest he be angry, and you perish in the way, for his wrath is quickly kindled. Blessed are all who take refuge in him” (v. 12).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm opens with a question that has echoed through history: “Why do the nations rage?” Power rises against God. The kings of the earth take counsel together against the LORD and his Anointed, saying, “Let us burst their bonds apart and cast away their cords from us.” They want to be free of God’s rule.

The answer from heaven is surprising: “He who sits in the heavens laughs.” It is not a laugh of amusement but of contempt for the futility of the plan. The nations are not a threat to God. Then he speaks in his wrath: “As for me, I have set my King on Zion, my holy hill.” The decision is made. The King is installed.

Then the King himself speaks: “I will tell of the decree: The LORD said to me, You are my Son; today I have begotten you.” In the Davidic covenant, the king was adopted as God’s son (2 Samuel 7:14). The New Testament sees the full meaning in Jesus. The Father said this at his baptism and the Transfiguration, and Paul says that Jesus was declared to be the Son of God in power by his resurrection (Romans 1:4, Acts 13:33). The Son is promised the nations as his heritage and the ends of the earth as his possession. This is the Great Commission in the language of the Psalms. The nations belong to Christ, and the mission of Acts is the fulfillment. He will rule with an iron rod. The nations that do not submit will be broken.

The psalm ends with a call to the kings to be wise: “Serve the LORD with fear, and rejoice with trembling. Kiss the Son.” To kiss the Son is to pay homage, to submit. “Lest he be angry, and you perish in the way.” And the final line is a gospel invitation: “Blessed are all who take refuge in him.” The Son who will judge is also the refuge. The first psalm opened with “Blessed is the man,” and the second ends with “Blessed are all who take refuge in him.”

In Acts, the church faces the rage of the rulers. They pray this psalm, and the place is shaken. The King is on the throne, and their courage comes from knowing it.

STEP 5

Connection

2 Samuel 7:12-16 is the Davidic covenant behind the psalm. Psalm 89:26-27 repeats the sonship. Acts 4:25-28 and 13:33 quote Psalm 2. Hebrews 1:5 and 5:5 apply it to Christ. Matthew 3:17 and 17:5 echo verse 7. Revelation 2:26-27, 12:5, and 19:15 use the iron rod. Romans 1:4 says he was declared the Son of God by the resurrection. Philippians 2:9-11 describes the whole earth bowing.

STEP 6

Application

When the news makes you anxious about rulers and nations, read verse 4 and remember who sits in the heavens.

Submit an area of your life that you have kept back from Christ's rule. Kiss the Son.

Take refuge in him today, by name, in prayer.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what rage and plotting you see around you.
- Thank him for the King he has set on Zion.
- Take refuge in the Son.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 100

"And there is salvation in no one else, for there is no other name under heaven given among men by which we must be saved."

ACTS 4:12

DAY 697 · WEEK 100

Psalm 16

You will not abandon my soul to Sheol

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Psalm · 11 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 16. David's confidence in the LORD reaches past death. Both Peter in Acts 2 and Paul in Acts 13 quote verse 10 as a prophecy of the resurrection of Jesus.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 16 is a "miktam" of David, a poem of trust. David asks for protection and then declares that the LORD is his chosen portion. The mood is quiet and joyful confidence. The psalm ends with a hope that goes beyond what David himself experienced, which is why Peter says David "foresaw and spoke about the resurrection of the Christ."

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Preserve me, O God, for in you I take refuge" (v. 1).
2. "I say to the LORD, You are my Lord; I have no good apart from you" (v. 2).
3. "The LORD is my chosen portion and my cup; you hold my lot" (v. 5).
4. "The lines have fallen for me in pleasant places; indeed, I have a beautiful inheritance" (v. 6).
5. "I bless the LORD who gives me counsel; in the night also my heart instructs me" (v. 7).
6. "I have set the LORD always before me; because he is at my right hand, I shall not be shaken" (v. 8).
7. "For you will not abandon my soul to Sheol, or let your holy one see corruption" (v. 10).
8. "You make known to me the path of life; in your presence there is fullness of joy; at your right hand are pleasures forevermore" (v. 11).

STEP 4

Interpretation

David begins by taking refuge: “Preserve me, O God, for in you I take refuge.” He affirms that the LORD is his Lord and that he has no good apart from him. All his delight is in the saints in the land, the people of God. Those who run after other gods multiply their sorrows.

Then the heart of the psalm: “The LORD is my chosen portion and my cup; you hold my lot.” In Israel, each tribe received a portion of land, except Levi, whose portion was the LORD himself. David applies this to himself. The LORD is his inheritance. The boundary lines have fallen in pleasant places. Having God, he has everything.

He blesses the LORD for counsel, even at night, and sets the LORD always before him. Because God is at his right hand, he will not be shaken. “Therefore my heart is glad, and my whole being rejoices; my flesh also dwells secure.”

Then comes verse 10: “For you will not abandon my soul to Sheol, or let your holy one see corruption.” In David’s own situation, this is a confident hope of rescue from death. But Peter says on Pentecost that David died and was buried, and his tomb is with us to this day. David was a prophet and knew God had sworn to set one of his descendants on his throne. “He foresaw and spoke about the resurrection of the Christ, that he was not abandoned to Hades, nor did his flesh see corruption.” The ultimate holy one is Jesus, whom God raised up. Paul argues in Acts 13:35-37 the same way.

The psalm ends with the path of life: “in your presence there is fullness of joy; at your right hand are pleasures forevermore.” This is the believer’s hope too. Because Christ rose, we too will be raised. The presence of God is not just a duty but a joy that never ends.

STEP 5

Connection

Numbers 18:20 and Deuteronomy 10:9 say the LORD is the Levites’ inheritance. Psalm 73:25-26 also says God is my portion. Psalm 17:15 expresses the hope of beholding God. Acts 2:25-32 and 13:35-37 quote and explain verse 10. 1 Corinthians 15:20-23 says Christ is the firstfruits of the resurrection. Hebrews 12:2 says Jesus endured the cross for the joy set before him. Matthew 5:8 promises that the pure in heart will see God.

STEP 6

Application

Say “You are my Lord; I have no good apart from you” as a prayer. What other goods compete for your heart?

Thank God for the beautiful inheritance of being his child.

Meditate on verse 11. What would it mean to live today in the path of life?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God that you have no good apart from him.

Thank him for the beautiful inheritance he has given you.

Thank him that he will not abandon your soul.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 100

"And there is salvation in no one else, for there is no other name under heaven given among men by which we must be saved."

ACTS 4:12

DAY 698 · WEEK 100

Psalm 110:1-7

Sit at my right hand, the exalted Christ

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Psalm · 7 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 110:1-7. This is the psalm quoted more than any other in the New Testament. Peter uses it on Pentecost to prove that Jesus is exalted at God's right hand. You first met it in the Old Testament. Read it now as the psalm of the ascension.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 110 is a psalm of David about a figure he calls "my Lord." The psalm describes a king-priest, seated at God's right hand, who will rule over his enemies. David himself was not a priest, and no king of Israel was both king and priest. Jesus asked the Pharisees how the Christ could be David's son when David called him Lord (Mark 12:35-37). The answer in Acts is that Jesus, risen and ascended, is the one to whom David spoke.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The LORD says to my Lord: Sit at my right hand, until I make your enemies your footstool" (v. 1).
2. "The LORD sends forth from Zion your mighty scepter. Rule in the midst of your enemies!" (v. 2).
3. "Your people will offer themselves freely on the day of your power" (v. 3).
4. "The LORD has sworn and will not change his mind" (v. 4).
5. "You are a priest forever after the order of Melchizedek" (v. 4).
6. "The Lord is at your right hand; he will shatter kings on the day of his wrath" (v. 5).
7. "He will execute judgment among the nations" (v. 6).
8. "He will drink from the brook by the way; therefore he will lift up his head" (v. 7).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with a conversation in heaven: “The LORD says to my Lord.” The first LORD is Yahweh, and the second is David’s Lord, the Messiah. The Messiah is invited to sit at God’s right hand, the place of honor and authority, until all his enemies are made his footstool. In Acts 2:34-35, Peter says that David did not ascend into the heavens, but he said, “The Lord said to my Lord, Sit at my right hand.” Jesus is the Lord to whom David referred. The ascension is the fulfillment of this verse.

The King’s rule extends from Zion. The mighty scepter is sent forth, and he rules in the midst of his enemies. This describes the current age: the King reigns now, though his enemies have not yet been put under his feet. His people willingly offer themselves, “in holy garments,” like an army of volunteers on the day of his power. This describes the church.

Then comes the astonishing oath in verse 4: “You are a priest forever after the order of Melchizedek.” Melchizedek in Genesis 14 was both king of Salem and priest of God Most High, who blessed Abraham. In Israel, kings came from Judah and priests from Levi. This verse promises a priest-king who is outside the Levitical order and whose priesthood is eternal. The book of Hebrews makes this central: Jesus is our great high priest, not by descent from Aaron, but by the oath of God, living forever to intercede for us (Hebrews 5 to 7). The LORD has sworn and will not change his mind. His priesthood is as secure as God’s word.

The last stanza describes the judgment: he will shatter kings on the day of his wrath, execute judgment among the nations, and shatter chiefs over the wide earth. He drinks from the brook by the way and lifts up his head, a picture of a victorious warrior refreshed in the pursuit. The psalm combines the two offices that Acts presents: Jesus as king ruling from heaven and as priest interceding for his people. And the victory is certain.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 14:18-20 is Melchizedek. Hebrews 1:13, 5:6, 7:1-28, 8:1, and 10:12-13 apply the psalm to Christ. Matthew 22:41-46 records Jesus asking about David’s Lord. Acts 2:34-36 uses verse 1. Ephesians 1:20-22 says God seated Christ at his right hand. 1 Corinthians 15:25 says he must reign until he has put all his enemies under his feet. Romans 8:34 says Christ is at the right hand of God, interceding for us. Zechariah 6:12-13 describes a priest on his throne.

STEP 6

Application

Remember that Jesus is both king and priest. Bring a need to him as King, and a failure to him as Priest.

Thank him for living forever to intercede for you.

Pray “until I make your enemies your footstool” over a difficult area of the world, and wait for him to act.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Worship Jesus at the Father’s right hand.
- Thank him for being a priest forever.
- Ask him to rule over your enemies, inside and out.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 100

“And there is salvation in no one else, for there is no other name under heaven given among men by which we must be saved.”

ACTS 4:12

DAY 699 · WEEK 100

Acts 6:8-8:3

Stephen's sermon and martyrdom; Saul appears

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Reading · 60 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Acts 6:8-8:3. Stephen, one of the seven, is full of grace and power. He is arrested, gives a long speech to the council, and is stoned. A young man named Saul is introduced. Read Stephen's last words slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Stephen, who was chosen to serve tables, also does signs and speaks with wisdom. Members of a synagogue argue with him and cannot withstand the Spirit by whom he spoke. They bring false witnesses who say he spoke against the temple and the law. His speech summarizes Israel's history from Abraham to Solomon and ends with an accusation. His death begins a persecution that scatters the church and sets the stage for the gospel's spread.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "And Stephen, full of grace and power, was doing great wonders and signs among the people" (6:8).
2. "And gazing at him, all who sat in the council saw that his face was like the face of an angel" (6:15).
3. "The God of glory appeared to our father Abraham when he was in Mesopotamia" (7:2).
4. "You stiff-necked people, uncircumcised in heart and ears, you always resist the Holy Spirit" (7:51).
5. "But he, full of the Holy Spirit, gazed into heaven and saw the glory of God, and Jesus standing at the right hand of God" (7:55).
6. "Lord Jesus, receive my spirit" (7:59).

7. “Lord, do not hold this sin against them” (7:60).
8. “And there arose on that day a great persecution against the church in Jerusalem” (8:1).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Stephen is accused of speaking blasphemous words against Moses and God. He is brought before the council, and his face looks like an angel’s. When the high priest asks if these things are so, Stephen gives a long speech. It is not a defense but a sermon, retelling the history of Israel. His point is that God has never been confined to one place. The God of glory appeared to Abraham in Mesopotamia, before there was a land or a temple. He was with Joseph in Egypt, with Moses in Midian and at Sinai. The tabernacle was a tent that moved, and Solomon built the temple, “yet the Most High does not dwell in houses made by hands.” At each stage, Israel resisted: Joseph’s brothers sold him, Israel rejected Moses, and they made a golden calf.

Then he turns the history on his hearers. “You stiff-necked people, uncircumcised in heart and ears, you always resist the Holy Spirit. As your fathers did, so do you. Which of the prophets did your fathers not persecute? They killed those who announced beforehand the coming of the Righteous One, whom you have now betrayed and murdered.” They are enraged.

Stephen, full of the Holy Spirit, looks into heaven and sees the glory of God and Jesus standing at the right hand of God. Everywhere else in the New Testament, Jesus is seated at the Father’s right hand. Here he stands, as if rising to receive his first martyr or to testify on his behalf. The crowd covers their ears, rushes him, drags him out of the city, and stones him. The witnesses lay their garments at the feet of a young man named Saul.

Stephen’s death echoes Jesus’ death. He prays, “Lord Jesus, receive my spirit,” and “Lord, do not hold this sin against them.” He kneels and dies, and Luke says he “fell asleep.” Saul approved of his execution. A great persecution arises, and the church is scattered throughout Judea and Samaria, except the apostles. Saul ravages the church, entering house after house. But as Jesus said in Acts 1:8, the gospel is about to move beyond Jerusalem. The scattering of the church is the way the word of God spreads.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 12 to 50, Exodus, and 1 Kings 6 and 8 are the history Stephen retells. Isaiah 66:1-2 is quoted in the speech. Jeremiah 7:1-15 warned about trusting in the temple. Deuteronomy 10:16 and Jeremiah 9:26 speak of uncircumcised hearts. Luke 23:34 and 23:46 are Jesus’

similar prayers. Matthew 5:10-12 blesses the persecuted. Philippians 1:29 says we are given the privilege of suffering for his sake. Acts 22:20 has Paul recalling Stephen's death.

STEP 6

Application

Notice how Stephen was able to forgive. Pray for someone who has harmed you.

Ask what "houses made by hands" you trust in: a building, a tradition, a routine? Remember that God goes with his people.

Pray for Christians who are persecuted today by name if you know them.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to fill you with the Holy Spirit.
- Ask him for courage, like Stephen's, to look to heaven.
- Pray for those who oppose you, as Stephen did.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 100

"And there is salvation in no one else, for there is no other name under heaven given among men by which we must be saved."

ACTS 4:12

DAY 700 · WEEK 100

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Acts 4:12 slowly, several times, and say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"And there is salvation in no one else, for there is no other name under heaven given among men by which we must be saved."

ACTS 4:12

REST

Meditation

Peter says this to the Jewish council that condemned Jesus. Hours earlier, he had been arrested, and now he stands before the same rulers, filled with the Holy Spirit.

"And there is salvation in no one else." This is a bold and exclusive claim. Peter does not say Jesus is one of many ways. He says salvation is found in him alone. This was not popular in the first century, and it is not popular now. But it is the heart of the gospel.

"For there is no other name under heaven." The name stands for the person, his authority and character. There is no other person anywhere who can do what Jesus does.

"Given among men." Salvation is a gift. God gave this name. We did not discover it by our efforts.

"By which we must be saved." The word "must" shows the necessity. We need saving. We cannot save ourselves. And there is a name by which we can be saved.

This verse is a comfort and a commission. It comforts because the way to God is open in Jesus. It commissions because if there is no other name, then people need to hear it.

When you are tempted to doubt that Jesus is enough, or when you are unsure about speaking of him, say this verse.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you read Peter's healing at the Beautiful Gate, his bold preaching, and his words to the council: "There is salvation in no other name." You saw the early church share its possessions, and you saw the hypocrisy of Ananias and Sapphira. You watched seven men be chosen to serve. Three psalms about the exalted Christ framed Peter's sermons: Psalm 2, in which the LORD sets his King on Zion and the nations rage in vain; Psalm 16, in which God does not abandon his holy one to Sheol; and Psalm 110, in which the Lord sits at God's right hand as priest and king. Finally, you saw Stephen preach to the council, see Jesus standing in heaven, and forgive his murderers as he died. A young man named Saul stood by. A great persecution scattered the church.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Peter and John said, "We cannot but speak of what we have seen and heard." What have you seen and heard of Jesus that you cannot keep to yourself?

Stephen forgave those who killed him, as Jesus did. Who is one person you need to forgive, and what would it take to pray for them?

The psalms of the week show Christ reigning at God's right hand. How does knowing that he is on the throne give you courage in the thing you fear most?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus that there is salvation in no other name, and that you have found it.

Ask him for the boldness of Peter.

Rest in him.

DAY 701 · WEEK 101

Acts 8:4-40

Philip; the Samaritans; Simon the magician; the Ethiopian

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Reading · 37 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Acts 8:4-40. Persecution scatters the believers and Philip takes the gospel to Samaria and then to an Ethiopian official. Notice how the gospel crosses ethnic and social lines, and how Philip uses Isaiah 53.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The persecution that began with Stephen scatters the church, and wherever they go, they preach. Philip, one of the seven, goes to Samaria, a region of mixed descent despised by Jews. This fulfills the second step of Acts 1:8. Then an angel sends him on a desert road, where he meets an Ethiopian court official, the first African convert recorded in Acts.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Now those who were scattered went about preaching the word” (8:4).
2. “Philip went down to the city of Samaria and proclaimed to them the Christ” (8:5).
3. “Then they laid their hands on them and they received the Holy Spirit” (8:17).
4. “May your silver perish with you, because you thought you could obtain the gift of God with money!” (8:20).
5. “So Philip ran to him and heard him reading Isaiah the prophet and asked, Do you understand what you are reading?” (8:30).
6. “Then Philip opened his mouth, and beginning with this Scripture he told him the good news about Jesus” (8:35).
7. “And when they came up out of the water, the Spirit of the Lord carried Philip away, and the eunuch saw him no more, and went on his way rejoicing” (8:39).

8 “So there was much joy in that city” (8:8).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Persecution scatters the church, but the believers go about preaching the word. What the enemy meant for harm, God used to spread the gospel. Philip goes to Samaria and proclaims Christ. The crowds pay attention as they see signs: unclean spirits come out, and the paralyzed and lame are healed. “So there was much joy in that city.” The long hostility between Jews and Samaritans begins to heal in Christ.

A man named Simon had amazed the Samaritans with magic, claiming to be someone great. He believes and is baptized, but later, when he sees the Spirit given through the laying on of hands by Peter and John, he offers money for the power. Peter replies sharply: “Your heart is not right before God. Repent.” Christians differ on whether Simon’s faith was genuine. The main lesson is that the gift of God cannot be bought, and the heart must be right.

The apostles Peter and John come from Jerusalem to the Samaritans, who had been baptized but had not yet received the Spirit. When they lay hands on them, the Spirit comes. This is an unusual sequence, and interpreters explain it as a special moment as the gospel crossed a boundary: the Samaritans received the Spirit in the presence of the apostles, so that the Jerusalem church would recognize them as full members. It is not the usual pattern, where the Spirit comes with faith (Romans 8:9).

An angel directs Philip to a desert road. He meets an Ethiopian court official, treasurer of the queen, who has been to Jerusalem to worship and is returning in his chariot, reading Isaiah 53. Philip asks, “Do you understand what you are reading?” “How can I, unless someone guides me?” The passage is the suffering servant, led like a sheep to the slaughter. “About whom does the prophet say this?” Philip begins with this Scripture and tells him the good news about Jesus. The man asks to be baptized in some water they pass. After the baptism, the Spirit takes Philip away, and the eunuch goes on his way rejoicing. Tradition holds that he carried the gospel to Africa.

The gospel is moving. It reached Samaritans, who were half-Jewish, and now an African who was excluded from the temple assembly under the law (Deuteronomy 23:1) but who is welcomed in Christ, as Isaiah 56:3-5 promised.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 53:7-8 is the passage the Ethiopian was reading. Isaiah 56:3-5 promises a place for eunuchs in God’s house. Psalm 68:31 says Cush will stretch out its hands to God. John 4:1-42 shows Jesus ministering in Samaria. Luke 9:51-56 shows earlier Samaritan hostility. 1 Peter

1:10-12 says the prophets searched for the sufferings of Christ. Luke 24:27 and 24:45 show Jesus opening the Scriptures. Romans 10:14-15 says how can they hear without someone preaching.

STEP 6

Application

Ask a friend about what they are reading, and be ready like Philip to explain from Scripture.

Notice whom your culture excludes. How could you bring the gospel to them?

Thank God that persecution cannot stop his word.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for using hard things to spread his word.
- Ask him to make you willing to go where he sends.
- Ask him to open your eyes to someone who is seeking.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 101

"To him all the prophets bear witness that everyone who believes in him receives forgiveness of sins through his name."

ACTS 10:43

DAY 702 · WEEK 101

Acts 9:1-43

Saul's conversion; Peter's miracles

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Reading · 43 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Acts 9:1-43. Saul meets the risen Christ on the Damascus road, is converted, and begins to preach. Peter heals Aeneas and raises Tabitha. Notice how Jesus identifies himself with his people.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Saul of Tarsus, a Pharisee trained under Gamaliel, was the leading persecutor of the church. He obtained letters from the high priest to arrest believers in Damascus. This is the pivotal conversion in Acts. Luke tells it here, and Paul tells it again in chapters 22 and 26. It changed the history of the church. The persecutor became the apostle to the Gentiles.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "But Saul, still breathing threats and murder against the disciples of the Lord, went to the high priest" (9:1).
2. "Saul, Saul, why are you persecuting me?" (9:4).
3. "Who are you, Lord? And he said, I am Jesus, whom you are persecuting" (9:5).
4. "Go, for he is a chosen instrument of mine to carry my name before the Gentiles and kings and the children of Israel" (9:15).
5. "For I will show him how much he must suffer for the sake of my name" (9:16).
6. "And immediately he proclaimed Jesus in the synagogues, saying, He is the Son of God" (9:20).
7. "So the church throughout all Judea and Galilee and Samaria had peace and was being built up" (9:31).

8 “Tabitha, arise” (9:40).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Saul is on the road to Damascus when a light from heaven flashes around him. He falls to the ground and hears a voice: “Saul, Saul, why are you persecuting me?” Notice that Jesus says “me.” To persecute the church is to persecute Christ. The church is united to him as a body to its head. “Who are you, Lord?” “I am Jesus, whom you are persecuting.” Saul has been convinced that Jesus was a blasphemer who died under God’s curse. Now he meets him, glorified.

Saul is blind and led by the hand into Damascus. For three days he neither eats nor drinks. A disciple named Ananias is told in a vision to go to him. Ananias protests: this man has done great harm to your saints. But the Lord says, “Go, for he is a chosen instrument of mine to carry my name before the Gentiles and kings and the children of Israel. For I will show him how much he must suffer for the sake of my name.” Ananias goes, lays hands on him, and calls him “Brother Saul.” Something like scales fall from his eyes, and he is baptized.

His conversion is the work of sovereign grace. He was not seeking Christ. He was breathing threats. Jesus found him. And his call was clear from the start: to carry Christ’s name to the Gentiles. Immediately he proclaims Jesus in the synagogues: “He is the Son of God.” The people are amazed. “Is this not the man who made havoc in Jerusalem?” He baffles the Jews by proving that Jesus is the Christ. The Jews plot to kill him, and the disciples let him down over the wall in a basket.

In Jerusalem, the disciples are afraid of him, but Barnabas takes him and brings him to the apostles. Barnabas, the encourager, is vital here. Luke notes that the church throughout Judea, Galilee, and Samaria had peace, was built up, and multiplied.

Peter heals Aeneas, a paralytic in Lydda, and raises Tabitha (Dorcas), a woman known for good works, in Joppa. Many believe. Peter stays in Joppa with Simon, a tanner, a detail that prepares for the next chapter, because tanners were ceremonially unclean.

STEP 5

Connection

Galatians 1:11-24 is Paul’s own account of his conversion. Philippians 3:4-11 tells how he counted all things as loss. 1 Timothy 1:12-16 says Christ came to save sinners, of whom Paul is the foremost. Ephesians 5:30 says we are members of his body. Matthew 25:40 and 25:45 speak of what is done to the least of these. 2 Corinthians 11:23-33 recounts his sufferings, including the basket. Romans 15:15-21 shows his Gentile mission.

STEP 6

Application

Remember your own conversion, however quiet. Write down how Christ found you.

Be an Ananias to someone who seems beyond reach. Is there someone you've written off?

Be a Barnabas: look for someone to encourage and bring into the fellowship.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for finding you, like Saul on the road.

Thank him for being one with his people.

Ask him to use you as he used Saul.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 101

"To him all the prophets bear witness that everyone who believes in him receives forgiveness of sins through his name."

ACTS 10:43

DAY 703 · WEEK 101

Acts 10:1-11:30

Cornelius, the Gentiles receive the Spirit

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Reading · 78 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Acts 10:1-11:30. God sends Peter to the household of Cornelius, a Roman centurion, and the Holy Spirit falls on Gentiles. Peter defends this in Jerusalem, and the church at Antioch is born. This is the hinge of Acts.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Cornelius, a centurion in Caesarea, is a God-fearer who prays and gives alms. Peter is in Joppa, hungry, praying on a rooftop. God arranges both visions to bring them together. For a Jew to enter a Gentile house was against custom, and it was a major step. The conversion of Cornelius opens the door for Gentiles to enter the church without becoming Jews first.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "A devout man who feared God with all his household, gave alms generously to the people, and prayed continually to God" (10:2).
2. "What God has made clean, do not call common" (10:15).
3. "Truly I understand that God shows no partiality, but in every nation anyone who fears him and does what is right is acceptable to him" (10:34).
4. "To him all the prophets bear witness that everyone who believes in him receives forgiveness of sins through his name" (10:43).
5. "While Peter was still saying these things, the Holy Spirit fell on all who heard the word" (10:44).
6. "Then to the Gentiles also God has granted repentance that leads to life" (11:18).

7. “When he came and saw the grace of God, he was glad, and he exhorted them all to remain faithful to the Lord with steadfast purpose” (11:23).

8. “And in Antioch the disciples were first called Christians” (11:26).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Peter has a vision of a sheet lowered from heaven filled with animals, clean and unclean. A voice says, “Rise, Peter; kill and eat.” Peter objects: “I have never eaten anything that is common or unclean.” The voice replies, “What God has made clean, do not call common.” This happens three times. While Peter wonders about the vision, the men from Cornelius arrive. The Spirit tells Peter to go with them. He realizes that the vision was not just about food but about people. “God has shown me that I should not call any person common or unclean.”

At Cornelius’s house, a crowd has gathered. Peter says, “Truly I understand that God shows no partiality, but in every nation anyone who fears him and does what is right is acceptable to him.” He then preaches the gospel: Jesus of Nazareth, anointed with the Holy Spirit and with power, went about doing good, was killed by hanging on a tree, and raised on the third day. “To him all the prophets bear witness that everyone who believes in him receives forgiveness of sins through his name.” Notice: forgiveness is received through faith in him. While Peter is still speaking, the Holy Spirit falls on all who hear. The Jewish believers with Peter are amazed that the gift of the Holy Spirit has been poured out on Gentiles, for they hear them speaking in tongues and extolling God. Peter asks, “Can anyone withhold water for baptizing these people who have received the Holy Spirit just as we have?” They are baptized.

When Peter returns to Jerusalem, believers criticize him: “You went to uncircumcised men and ate with them.” Peter explains step by step. “If then God gave the same gift to them as he gave to us when we believed in the Lord Jesus Christ, who was I that I could stand in God’s way?” They fall silent and glorify God: “Then to the Gentiles also God has granted repentance that leads to life.”

Meanwhile, those scattered after Stephen’s death have reached Antioch, where some preached to Greeks as well, and many believed. The Jerusalem church sends Barnabas, who sees the grace of God and rejoices, then fetches Saul. For a year they teach a great company, “and in Antioch the disciples were first called Christians.” The church in Antioch will become the base for the first missionary journey.

STEP 5

Connection

Leviticus 11 is the food laws. Genesis 12:3 promised blessing to all nations through Abraham. Isaiah 49:6 is the light to the Gentiles. Deuteronomy 10:17 says God is not partial. Ephesians 2:11-22 describes the Gentiles made near. Galatians 2:11-14 shows Peter struggling again with table fellowship. Romans 2:11 and 3:29-30 say God is the God of Gentiles as well. Mark 7:19 says Jesus declared all foods clean.

STEP 6

Application

Ask who you have been treating as “common or unclean,” and ask God to change your view.

Invite someone from a different background to share a meal with you this week.

Remember that you are among the Gentiles to whom God granted repentance that leads to life.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he shows no partiality.

Thank him for sending the gospel to you.

Ask him to forgive where you have shown partiality.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 101

“To him all the prophets bear witness that everyone who believes in him receives forgiveness of sins through his name.”

ACTS 10:43

DAY 704 · WEEK 101

Acts 12:1-13:52

Peter freed; the first missionary journey begins

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Reading · 77 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Acts 12:1-13:52. James is killed, Peter is freed from prison, Herod dies, and the Holy Spirit sends out Barnabas and Saul on the first missionary journey. Paul preaches in Pisidian Antioch. Notice the role of prayer and the Spirit in every stage.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Persecution intensifies under King Herod Agrippa I. He kills James the brother of John and arrests Peter. Then the scene moves to Antioch, where the church worships and fasts. What follows is a new stage in Acts: the church deliberately sends missionaries to the Gentile world. From here on, the focus shifts from Peter to Paul, and the geography widens.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "So Peter was kept in prison, but earnest prayer for him was made to God by the church" (12:5).
2. "And the angel struck Peter on the side and woke him, saying, Get up quickly" (12:7).
3. "But the word of God increased and multiplied" (12:24).
4. "While they were worshiping the Lord and fasting, the Holy Spirit said, Set apart for me Barnabas and Saul for the work to which I have called them" (13:2).
5. "And by him everyone who believes is freed from everything from which you could not be freed by the law of Moses" (13:39).
6. "For so the Lord has commanded us, saying, I have made you a light for the Gentiles, that you may bring salvation to the ends of the earth" (13:47).

7. “And when the Gentiles heard this, they began rejoicing and glorifying the word of the Lord, and as many as were appointed to eternal life believed” (13:48).

8. “And the disciples were filled with joy and with the Holy Spirit” (13:52).

STEP 4

Interpretation

James is executed with the sword, and Herod, seeing that it pleases the Jews, arrests Peter. He plans to bring him out after Passover. “So Peter was kept in prison, but earnest prayer for him was made to God by the church.” The night before the trial, Peter is sleeping between two soldiers, chained. An angel wakes him, the chains fall off, and the iron gate opens by itself. Peter thinks it is a vision until he is in the street. At the house of Mary, the mother of John Mark, the church is praying, and when Rhoda announces that Peter is at the door, they say, “You are out of your mind!” Their prayers were answered, and they could hardly believe it. Herod later gives a speech, the crowd cries, “The voice of a god, and not of a man!” and an angel strikes him down because he did not give God the glory. “But the word of God increased and multiplied.” Kings fall, and the word advances.

In Antioch, the church has prophets and teachers, including Barnabas and Saul. While they are worshiping and fasting, the Holy Spirit says, “Set apart for me Barnabas and Saul for the work to which I have called them.” After fasting and prayer, they lay hands on them and send them. They sail to Cyprus, where Saul, who is now called Paul, confronts a magician and the proconsul Sergius Paulus believes. Then they go to Pisidian Antioch, where Paul preaches in the synagogue. His sermon moves from Israel’s history to David and then to Jesus, the Savior raised from the dead. “Let it be known to you therefore, brothers, that through this man forgiveness of sins is proclaimed to you, and by him everyone who believes is freed from everything from which you could not be freed by the law of Moses.” This is justification by faith in Christ.

The next Sabbath, almost the whole city gathers. The Jews are jealous and contradict Paul. Paul and Barnabas say boldly, “It was necessary that the word of God be spoken first to you. Since you thrust it aside, behold, we are turning to the Gentiles.” They cite Isaiah 49:6, “I have made you a light for the Gentiles.” The Gentiles rejoice, and “as many as were appointed to eternal life believed.” God’s sovereign choice and the human response are held together. The word spreads throughout the region. The Jews stir up persecution and drive them out, but the disciples are “filled with joy and with the Holy Spirit.”

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 49:6 is the commission quoted in 13:47. Psalm 2:7, Isaiah 55:3, and Psalm 16:10 are quoted in Paul's sermon in 13:33-35. Romans 3:21-28 and Galatians 2:16 develop justification by faith. Genesis 12:3 shows the Abrahamic promise at work. Romans 9 to 11 discusses God's election and Israel. Ephesians 1:4-5 speaks of being chosen. 2 Corinthians 12:10 says that when I am weak, then I am strong. Psalm 34:7 says the angel of the LORD encamps around those who fear him.

STEP 6

Application

Pray earnestly for someone in danger or need, and expect God to answer, even if your faith is small.

Ask what the Spirit might be setting you apart for. Fast and pray with your church.

Remember that forgiveness is received by faith, not by law.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for answering the church's prayers.
- Ask him to set apart workers for his harvest.
- Ask him to make you willing to go or to send.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 101

"To him all the prophets bear witness that everyone who believes in him receives forgiveness of sins through his name."

ACTS 10:43

DAY 705 · WEEK 101

Psalm 67

May God be gracious, all the nations praise him

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Psalm · 7 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 67. It is a short prayer that God would bless his people so that all nations would know and praise him. It reads like the first missionary journey of Acts 13 turned into song.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 67 begins with the priestly blessing of Numbers 6:24-26 ("the LORD bless you and keep you; the LORD make his face to shine upon you"), but turns it outward. The blessing is not an end in itself. Israel is blessed so that the nations may be blessed. That is the Abrahamic promise at work, which is the reason why Acts 13 quotes Isaiah 49:6. Reading it as Paul and Barnabas set out on their journey makes the missions theme clear.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "May God be gracious to us and bless us and make his face to shine upon us" (v. 1).
2. "That your way may be known on earth" (v. 2).
3. "Your saving power among all nations" (v. 2).
4. "Let the peoples praise you, O God; let all the peoples praise you!" (v. 3).
5. "Let the nations be glad and sing for joy" (v. 4).
6. "For you judge the peoples with equity and guide the nations upon earth" (v. 4).
7. "The earth has yielded its increase; God, our God, has blessed us" (v. 6).
8. "God shall bless us; let all the ends of the earth fear him!" (v. 7).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm starts with a prayer for blessing: “May God be gracious to us and bless us and make his face to shine upon us.” This is borrowed from the benediction that Aaron and his sons spoke over Israel. But the next word is “that.” The blessing has a purpose: “that your way may be known on earth, your saving power among all nations.” Israel asks for God’s favor, not for its own sake, but so that the whole world may see and know the LORD.

The refrain follows: “Let the peoples praise you, O God; let all the peoples praise you!” It appears twice, in verses 3 and 5, as the center of the psalm. The goal of all God’s work is that the nations praise him. In between, the psalm says why the nations can be glad: God judges the peoples with equity and guides the nations upon earth. His rule is just and good. The nations are not simply objects of judgment but people whom God guides. This is a vision of a world finally under the good rule of the true God.

Then the psalm returns to blessing: “The earth has yielded its increase; God, our God, has blessed us. God shall bless us; let all the ends of the earth fear him!” The harvest is the sign of God’s blessing, and it becomes a motive for missions. The psalm ends with the whole world fearing the LORD.

This is the pattern of the Abrahamic covenant: “I will bless you… so that you will be a blessing… and in you all the families of the earth shall be blessed.” It is the pattern of Acts: the apostles are sent to the nations. And it is the church’s prayer today. We pray for God to bless us, not for comfort alone, but so that we can be used to bless others and bring praise to his name. The final picture, in Revelation 7:9, is of people from every nation, tribe, people, and language praising God. Psalm 67 is the prayer that leads there.

STEP 5

Connection

Numbers 6:22-27 is the priestly blessing. Genesis 12:1-3 is the Abrahamic promise. Isaiah 49:6 and 2:2-4 speak of the nations coming to the LORD. Psalm 117 and 96 also call the nations to praise. Matthew 28:19-20 gives the Great Commission. Acts 13:47 quotes Isaiah 49:6. Romans 15:9-12 collects Old Testament texts on the Gentiles praising God. Revelation 7:9-10 pictures the fulfillment.

STEP 6

Application

Pray this psalm for your church: “Bless us so that your way may be known on earth.”

Pray for one unreached people group by name. Look up a missionary or agency your church supports.

Ask how God's blessings to you can overflow to others.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to be gracious to you and make his face shine on you.
- Ask him to let his way be known on earth.
- Pray for a nation or people group to know him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 101

"To him all the prophets bear witness that everyone who believes in him receives forgiveness of sins through his name."

ACTS 10:43

DAY 706 · WEEK 101

Psalm 87

Zion as mother of all peoples

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Psalm · 7 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 87. This short psalm imagines Zion as the mother city of all peoples, including Israel's historic enemies. Read slowly. It is a puzzling psalm that becomes clear in light of Acts.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 87 is a song of the sons of Korah, a hymn of Zion. It is brief and surprising. God registers people from Egypt (Rahab), Babylon, Philistia, Tyre, and Cush as born in Zion. These are Israel's old enemies, and now they are citizens of the city of God. This is the Old Testament's most vivid picture of the nations coming in.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "On the holy mount stands the city he founded" (v. 1).
2. "The LORD loves the gates of Zion more than all the dwelling places of Jacob" (v. 2).
3. "Glorious things of you are spoken, O city of God" (v. 3).
4. "Among those who know me I mention Rahab and Babylon" (v. 4).
5. "Behold, Philistia and Tyre, with Cush" (v. 4).
6. "And of Zion it shall be said, This one and that one were born in her; for the Most High himself will establish her" (v. 5).
7. "The LORD records, as he registers the peoples, This one was born there" (v. 6).
8. "Singers and dancers alike say, All my springs are in you" (v. 7).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm opens with the city God founded on the holy mount. The LORD loves the gates of Zion more than all the other dwelling places of Jacob. Glorious things are spoken of her. And then the surprising list begins. God says, “Among those who know me I mention Rahab and Babylon.” Rahab is a poetic name for Egypt. These were the oppressors in Israel’s story, the powers that enslaved and exiled. And Philistia, Tyre, and Cush (Ethiopia) are also named. They are mentioned among those who know the LORD.

Verse 4 ends: “This one was born there.” And verse 5 explains: “Of Zion it shall be said, This one and that one were born in her.” Foreigners are said to be born in Zion. The citizens of Zion include people from every nation. The LORD himself keeps the register: “The LORD records, as he registers the peoples, This one was born there.” When the census is read, the nations are on the list.

This is the idea of the new birth applied to peoples. The New Testament says that believers are born from above (John 3:3). Paul says in Galatians 4:26 that the Jerusalem above is free, and she is our mother. Hebrews 12:22 says we have come to Mount Zion, to the city of the living God, the heavenly Jerusalem. Ephesians 2:19 says Gentiles are no longer strangers and aliens but fellow citizens with the saints and members of the household of God.

This is what Acts is unfolding. An Ethiopian official from Cush believes through Philip. Cornelius, a Roman, receives the Spirit. Antioch becomes a church of Jews and Greeks. Psalm 87 pictures the endpoint, in which former enemies sing together and say, “All my springs are in you.” All the sources of joy and life are found in Zion, and Christ is the temple and the center. The gospel does not abolish the identity of nations but brings them into one family, where God registers each as born there.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 19:19-25 pictures Egypt and Assyria joined with Israel as a blessing. Isaiah 2:2-4 and 56:6-8 describe the nations coming to Zion. Galatians 4:26 speaks of the Jerusalem above as our mother. Hebrews 12:22-24 says we have come to Zion. Ephesians 2:11-22 says Gentiles are fellow citizens. Philippians 3:20 says our citizenship is in heaven. Revelation 21:24-26 pictures the nations bringing their glory into the city.

STEP 6

Application

Imagine a person from a nation or group you struggle with, and picture them registered as born in Zion with you.

Thank God for the family of the church, which includes people unlike you.

Pray that old enmities in your family or church would be healed in Christ.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for registering people from every nation in his city.

Ask him to make you welcoming.

Thank him that you are born there.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 101

"To him all the prophets bear witness that everyone who believes in him receives forgiveness of sins through his name."

ACTS 10:43

DAY 707 · WEEK 101

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Acts 10:43 slowly, several times, and say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"To him all the prophets bear witness that everyone who believes in him receives forgiveness of sins through his name."

ACTS 10:43

REST

Meditation

Peter says this in the house of Cornelius, a Roman, in the first sermon to the Gentiles. In one verse, he sums up the gospel.

"To him all the prophets bear witness." The Old Testament is a witness to Jesus. Moses, David, Isaiah, and the others all point to him. This is why we read the whole Bible as one story.

"That everyone who believes in him." Notice the word "everyone." The offer is universal, to Jew and Gentile, to the devout and the sinner. The one condition is belief: trust in Jesus.

"Receives forgiveness of sins." Forgiveness is the great need and the great gift. It is received, not earned. The word "receives" means we hold out empty hands.

"Through his name." Forgiveness comes through his name, that is, through who he is and what he has done. We do not come in our own name or by our own merit.

When you wonder whether the gospel is really for you, or whether you are too far from God, say this verse. It was spoken to a Gentile soldier, and it is for everyone who believes.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week the gospel moved out from Jerusalem. After Stephen's death, the church was scattered, and Philip took the word to Samaria and met an Ethiopian official reading Isaiah 53. You saw the risen Jesus stop Saul on the road to Damascus and ask, "Why are you persecuting me?" You watched God show Peter in a vision that he should not call any person common or unclean, and then pour out the Holy Spirit on Cornelius's Gentile household. The Antioch church, full of Jews and Greeks, set apart Barnabas and Saul, and Paul preached to the Gentiles in Pisidian Antioch, citing Isaiah 49:6. Psalm 67 and Psalm 87 gave you songs for the nations: the blessing that spills over to the world and the city where former enemies are registered as born in Zion.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Jesus asked Saul, "Why are you persecuting me?" What does it mean that Christ identifies so closely with his people?

God told Peter, "What God has made clean, do not call common." Who do you tend to see as outside the reach of the gospel, and how could God change that?

Psalm 67 prays for God's blessing so that all nations will praise him. How does that change how you think about your own blessings?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that everyone who believes in Jesus receives forgiveness.

Thank him for sending his word to the nations.

Rest in his forgiveness.

DAY 708 · WEEK 102

Psalm 117

Praise the LORD, all nations, the mission in two verses

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Psalm · 2 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 117. It has only two verses. You met it earlier, in the unit on Luke. Read it now as the whole mission of Acts in miniature: the call to the nations and the reason.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 117 is the shortest psalm and the shortest chapter in the Bible. Paul quotes it in Romans 15:11 to show that the Gentiles were always meant to glorify God. Placed here, in the middle of the first missionary journey, it is a summary of what Paul and Barnabas are doing: calling all nations to praise the LORD because of his steadfast love and faithfulness.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Praise the LORD, all nations!” (v. 1).
2. “Extol him, all peoples!” (v. 1).
3. “For great is his steadfast love” (v. 2).
4. “Toward us” (v. 2).
5. “The faithfulness of the LORD” (v. 2).
6. “Endures forever” (v. 2).
7. “Praise the LORD!” (v. 2).
8. “All peoples” (v. 1).

STEP 4

Interpretation

In two verses, the psalm gives the mission's command and its motive. The command is to praise: "Praise the LORD, all nations! Extol him, all peoples!" The scope is every nation and every people. The motive is in verse 2: "For great is his steadfast love toward us, and the faithfulness of the LORD endures forever."

Notice the logic. The nations are to praise because of God's love "toward us," toward Israel. The LORD's covenant faithfulness to one people is the reason for the whole world to worship. In Acts, this is the heart of the mission. The God who kept his promises to Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob, to David, and to Israel in sending Jesus, is the God who is calling the nations. Paul preaches in Pisidian Antioch that God has fulfilled the promise made to the fathers. The Gentiles rejoice and glorify the word of the Lord. They are the "all peoples" called to praise.

Look at Paul's use in Romans 15: Christ became a servant to the circumcised to show God's truthfulness, in order to confirm the promises given to the patriarchs, and in order that the Gentiles might glorify God for his mercy. Then Paul quotes a chain of passages, including this psalm: "Praise the Lord, all nations, and let all the peoples extol him." The psalmist wrote this long before, and Paul says it is being fulfilled.

The psalm also gives the mission its fuel. Missionaries do not go out because of a program but because the LORD is worthy of praise from every people. Missions exists because worship doesn't yet. The great goal is that all nations praise him, and the great ground is his steadfast love and faithfulness.

The psalm ends as it began, with "Praise the LORD!" We can do the same, grateful that his love is great toward us, and his faithfulness endures forever.

STEP 5

Connection

Romans 15:8-12 quotes this psalm. Psalm 67, 96, 98, and 100 are similar missionary psalms. Genesis 12:3 and 22:18 are the Abrahamic promise. Isaiah 49:6 and 56:7 point to the nations coming. Acts 13:47-48 shows Gentiles glorifying the word of the Lord. Revelation 7:9-10 pictures the fulfillment.

STEP 6

Application

Recite the psalm aloud each morning this week. It takes ten seconds.

Name a nation or people group and pray the psalm over them.

Thank God that you belong to "all nations" because of his steadfast love.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Praise the LORD with all the nations.

Thank him for his great steadfast love toward us.

Pray for his word to reach someone far away.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 102

"Believe in the Lord Jesus, and you will be saved, you and your household."

ACTS 16:31

DAY 709 · WEEK 102

Acts 14:1-28

The first journey concludes; Lystra and Derbe

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Reading · 28 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Acts 14:1-28. Paul and Barnabas preach in Iconium, Lystra, and Derbe. They heal a man, are mistaken for gods, and Paul is stoned. They return, strengthening the churches and appointing elders. Read Paul's speech at Lystra (vv. 15 to 17) carefully.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The first missionary journey continues from Pisidian Antioch to Iconium, Lystra, and Derbe, cities in what is now central Turkey. The pattern is that Paul first speaks in the synagogue, the Gentiles respond, and the Jews stir up opposition. At Lystra there is no synagogue, and the population is pagan, so Paul's message begins with God as Creator, a template for preaching to those with no biblical background.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "So they remained for a long time, speaking boldly for the Lord, who bore witness to the word of his grace" (14:3).
2. "The gods have come down to us in the likeness of men!" (14:11).
3. "We also are men, of like nature with you, and we bring you good news, that you should turn from these vain things to a living God, who made the heaven and the earth and the sea and all that is in them" (14:15).
4. "Yet he did not leave himself without witness, for he did good by giving you rains from heaven and fruitful seasons, satisfying your hearts with food and gladness" (14:17).
5. "They stoned Paul and dragged him out of the city, supposing that he was dead" (14:19).
6. "Through many tribulations we must enter the kingdom of God" (14:22).

7. “And when they had appointed elders for them in every church, with prayer and fasting they committed them to the Lord in whom they had believed” (14:23).

8. “They declared all that God had done with them, and how he had opened a door of faith to the Gentiles” (14:27).

STEP 4

Interpretation

In Iconium, a great number of Jews and Greeks believe, but unbelieving Jews stir up the Gentiles. Paul and Barnabas stay a long time, speaking boldly, with signs and wonders, and then flee when a plot to stone them arises.

At Lystra, Paul sees a man crippled from birth who has faith to be made well, and says, “Stand upright on your feet.” The man leaps up and walks. The crowd shouts in their local language, “The gods have come down to us in the likeness of men!” They call Barnabas Zeus and Paul Hermes, and the priest of Zeus brings oxen and garlands to offer sacrifice. Paul and Barnabas tear their garments and rush into the crowd: “Men, why are you doing these things? We also are men, of like nature with you.” Their message is not about themselves but about the living God: “turn from these vain things to a living God, who made the heaven and the earth and the sea.” Though in past generations God allowed all the nations to walk in their own ways, he has not left himself without witness, giving rain and fruitful seasons, satisfying hearts with food and gladness. This is the first example in Acts of preaching to people with no Scriptural background. Paul starts with creation, God’s goodness, and the folly of idolatry, and only later comes to Christ. Even so, they can scarcely restrain the people from sacrificing.

Then Jews arrive from Antioch and Iconium, win over the crowds, and stone Paul and drag him out of the city, thinking him dead. The people who wanted to worship him now try to kill him. But as the disciples gather around him, he gets up and goes back into the city. The next day he leaves for Derbe.

They return the way they came, strengthening the disciples and encouraging them to continue in the faith: “Through many tribulations we must enter the kingdom of God.” They appoint elders in every church, with prayer and fasting. Back in Antioch, they report “all that God had done with them, and how he had opened a door of faith to the Gentiles.” It is God who opens the door and God who does the work.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 1 and Psalm 146:6 describe God as the maker of heaven and earth. Psalm 145:15-16 says he satisfies the desire of every living thing. Romans 1:18-23 and 2:14-15 describe general revelation. Acts 17:22-31 is Paul's similar speech in Athens. 2 Corinthians 11:25 recalls the stoning. 2 Timothy 3:11 mentions his sufferings at Lystra. Titus 1:5 shows Titus appointing elders. John 16:33 says in the world you will have tribulation.

STEP 6

Application

Practice explaining the gospel to someone with no Christian background, starting with creation.

Remember that tribulation is not a sign you're off track. It is part of the road to the kingdom.

Thank God for the elders in your church, and pray for them.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for his goodness in rain, seasons, food, and gladness.

Ask him to keep you from taking his glory.

Ask him to strengthen believers who face hardship.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 102

"Believe in the Lord Jesus, and you will be saved, you and your household."

ACTS 16:31

DAY 710 · WEEK 102

Acts 15:1-41

The Jerusalem Council; the second journey begins

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Reading · 41 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Acts 15:1-41. Some teach that Gentiles must be circumcised to be saved. The apostles and elders meet in Jerusalem to decide. Notice how they reason, who speaks, and what they conclude. Then Paul and Barnabas part ways.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

This is the central chapter of Acts and arguably the most important meeting in the early church. The question is whether Gentile believers must become Jews, keeping the law of Moses, to be saved. If the answer were yes, the gospel would become another form of Judaism. Around AD 49, the apostles and elders meet in Jerusalem. The decision shapes the whole Christian faith.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “But some men came down from Judea and were teaching the brothers, Unless you are circumcised according to the custom of Moses, you cannot be saved” (15:1).
2. “And God, who knows the heart, bore witness to them, by giving them the Holy Spirit just as he did to us” (15:8).
3. “Now therefore why are you putting God to the test by placing a yoke on the neck of the disciples that neither our fathers nor we have been able to bear?” (15:10).
4. “But we believe that we will be saved through the grace of the Lord Jesus, just as they will” (15:11).
5. “After this I will return, and I will rebuild the tent of David that has fallen” (15:16).

6. “Therefore my judgment is that we should not trouble those of the Gentiles who turn to God” (15:19).

7. “For it has seemed good to the Holy Spirit and to us to lay on you no greater burden than these requirements” (15:28).

8. “And there arose a sharp disagreement, so that they separated from each other” (15:39).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The trouble starts in Antioch when men from Judea teach that circumcision is necessary for salvation. Paul and Barnabas dispute with them, and the church sends them to Jerusalem to settle the matter. There they report how God had opened a door to the Gentiles, but some believers who belonged to the party of the Pharisees insist that Gentiles must be circumcised and keep the law of Moses.

After much debate, Peter stands. He reminds them that God chose that Gentiles should hear the gospel from his mouth, and that God, who knows the heart, bore witness by giving the Gentiles the Holy Spirit as he did to the Jews, “having cleansed their hearts by faith.” To impose the law now would be to put God to the test with a yoke that neither they nor their fathers could bear. The conclusion is the heart of the gospel: “We believe that we will be saved through the grace of the Lord Jesus, just as they will.” Jews are saved the same way as Gentiles, by grace, not by law.

Barnabas and Paul describe the signs and wonders God did among the Gentiles. Then James, the brother of Jesus, speaks. He quotes Amos 9:11-12: God will rebuild the fallen tent of David so that the rest of mankind may seek the Lord, and all the Gentiles who are called by his name. The inclusion of the Gentiles is not a departure from the Old Testament but its fulfillment. This is a key text for the progressive covenantalism you have been reading: the Davidic kingdom, restored in Christ, includes the nations. James gives his judgment: do not trouble the Gentiles who turn to God, but write to them to abstain from things polluted by idols, from sexual immorality, from what has been strangled, and from blood. These requests promoted fellowship between Jew and Gentile believers, who would share tables. The letter goes out, saying, “It has seemed good to the Holy Spirit and to us.” The Gentiles rejoice at its encouragement.

Chapter 15 ends with sadness. Paul proposes revisiting the churches, but Barnabas wants to take John Mark again, who had left them on the first journey. Paul refuses. There is a sharp disagreement, and they part. Barnabas takes Mark to Cyprus. Paul chooses Silas and goes through Syria and Cilicia. God uses even this to double the missionary effort. Later Paul writes that Mark is “very useful” to him (2 Timothy 4:11).

STEP 5

Connection

Amos 9:11-12 is James's text. Genesis 17 is the covenant of circumcision. Galatians 2:1-21 is Paul's account of the same events. Galatians 5:1-6 insists that circumcision no longer matters. Romans 3:28 and 4:1-12 teach justification by faith apart from works of the law. Ephesians 2:8-9 says we are saved by grace through faith. Colossians 2:11-17 shows circumcision and food laws fulfilled in Christ. 2 Timothy 4:11 mentions Mark.

STEP 6

Application

Where are you tempted to add something to grace, such as a rule, a ritual, or a performance?

Rejoice in verse 11 and say it aloud: saved through the grace of the Lord Jesus.

If you've had a sharp disagreement with a fellow believer, pray for reconciliation and for God to use it for good.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God that you are saved through the grace of the Lord Jesus.
- Confess where you try to add to grace.
- Ask him to help you welcome others without adding burdens.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 102

"Believe in the Lord Jesus, and you will be saved, you and your household."

ACTS 16:31

DAY 711 · WEEK 102

Acts 16:1-40

Timothy; the Macedonian call; Lydia; the Philippian jailer

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Reading · 40 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Acts 16:1-40. Timothy joins Paul, a vision calls them to Macedonia, Lydia believes in Philippi, and a jailer is converted after an earthquake. Notice how each conversion looks different and how each family is included.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The second missionary journey takes Paul and Silas through Asia Minor. In Lystra, they pick up Timothy, a young disciple of Jewish and Greek parentage. The Spirit forbids them to speak in Asia and Bithynia, and in a night vision, a man of Macedonia calls them to cross to Europe. The gospel reaches the continent for the first time at Philippi, a Roman colony.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Paul wanted Timothy to accompany him, and he took him and circumcised him because of the Jews who were in those places, for they all knew that his father was a Greek” (16:3).
2. “A man of Macedonia was standing there, urging him and saying, Come over to Macedonia and help us” (16:9).
3. “The Lord opened her heart to pay attention to what was said by Paul” (16:14).
4. “About midnight Paul and Silas were praying and singing hymns to God, and the prisoners were listening to them” (16:25).
5. “And suddenly there was a great earthquake, so that the foundations of the prison were shaken” (16:26).
6. “Sirs, what must I do to be saved?” (16:30).

7. “Believe in the Lord Jesus, and you will be saved, you and your household” (16:31).
8. “He rejoiced along with his entire household that he had believed in God” (16:34).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Timothy, whose mother is a believing Jew and whose father is Greek, is well spoken of. Paul circumcises him, not because it is necessary for salvation, as Acts 15 has just settled, but to avoid hindering the gospel among Jews. This shows Paul’s flexibility on matters of culture. Titus, a Gentile, was not circumcised under pressure (Galatians 2:3). The difference is the reason: Timothy’s circumcision was a choice for mission, not a requirement for salvation.

The vision leads them to Philippi. On the Sabbath, outside the gate by the river, they find women gathered to pray. Lydia, a dealer in purple goods and a worshiper of God, listens. “The Lord opened her heart to pay attention to what was said by Paul.” Conversion is God’s work. She is baptized with her household and invites them to stay at her house.

Then a slave girl with a spirit of divination follows them, shouting. Paul commands the spirit to come out in the name of Jesus Christ. Her owners, who lost their profit, drag Paul and Silas before the magistrates. They are beaten with rods and thrown into the inner prison with their feet in stocks. At midnight they are praying and singing hymns, and the prisoners are listening. A great earthquake shakes the prison, the doors open, and everyone’s chains come loose. The jailer, thinking the prisoners have escaped, is about to kill himself. Paul cries, “Do not harm yourself, for we are all here.” The jailer trembles, falls before Paul and Silas, and asks, “Sirs, what must I do to be saved?” They answer, “Believe in the Lord Jesus, and you will be saved, you and your household.”

This is the clearest answer in the Bible to the question of how to be saved: believe in the Lord Jesus. Then they speak the word of the Lord to him and his household. That same night he washes their wounds and is baptized with all his family. He brings them into his house and sets food before them, “and rejoiced along with his entire household that he had believed in God.” In the morning, the magistrates send word to release them, and Paul insists on a public apology, because he is a Roman citizen. This protects the young church.

Three conversions: a wealthy businesswoman, a slave girl freed from a spirit, and a rough jailer. The gospel crosses class and gender lines.

STEP 5

Connection

2 Timothy 1:5 and 3:14-15 describe Timothy's heritage. Galatians 2:3-5 is Titus not circumcised. 1 Corinthians 9:19-23 explains Paul's flexibility for the gospel. Philippians 1:1-11 is Paul's letter to the same church. Romans 10:9-13 says if you confess with your mouth and believe in your heart, you will be saved. John 6:29 says to believe in him whom he has sent. 1 Peter 2:21-23 and 4:12-16 treat unjust suffering. Psalm 40:3 speaks of a new song.

STEP 6

Application

Memorize Acts 16:31. It is the memory verse of this week.

Sing a hymn tonight even if things are hard, as Paul did in prison.

Pray for the "household" in your life, that the whole family would believe.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to open your heart and the hearts of those you love.
- Thank him for shaking prisons and setting captives free.
- Tell him what you need to be set free from.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 102

"Believe in the Lord Jesus, and you will be saved, you and your household."

ACTS 16:31

DAY 712 · WEEK 102

Acts 17:1-18:28

Thessalonica; Berea; Athens; Corinth

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Reading · 76 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Acts 17:1-18:28. Paul preaches in Thessalonica, is received nobly in Berea, speaks to the philosophers at Athens, and stays a year and a half in Corinth. Read the Areopagus speech (17:22-31) slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Paul and Silas travel southwest from Philippi through Amphipolis and Apollonia to Thessalonica. Opposition drives them to Berea, then Paul goes on to Athens, the intellectual capital of the Greek world. Finally, he reaches Corinth, a wealthy and immoral port city, where he stays eighteen months. Along the way he meets Priscilla and Aquila.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Explaining and proving that it was necessary for the Christ to suffer and to rise from the dead” (17:2-3).
2. “Now these Jews were more noble than those in Thessalonica; they received the word with all eagerness, examining the Scriptures daily to see if these things were so” (17:11).
3. “For as I passed along and observed the objects of your worship, I found also an altar with this inscription: To the unknown god. What therefore you worship as unknown, this I proclaim to you” (17:23).
4. “The God who made the world and everything in it, being Lord of heaven and earth, does not live in temples made by man” (17:24).
5. “In him we live and move and have our being” (17:28).

6. “Because he has fixed a day on which he will judge the world in righteousness by a man whom he has appointed; and of this he has given assurance to all by raising him from the dead” (17:31).

7. “Do not be afraid, but go on speaking and do not be silent, for I am with you” (18:9-10).

8. “They took him and explained to him the way of God more accurately” (18:26).

STEP 4

Interpretation

In Thessalonica, Paul reasons from the Scriptures for three Sabbaths, explaining and proving that the Christ had to suffer and rise from the dead, and that Jesus is the Christ. Some believe, including many God-fearing Greeks, but jealous Jews form a mob. The accusation is that they are “turning the world upside down” and saying there is another king, Jesus. In Berea, the Jews are more noble: they receive the word eagerly and examine the Scriptures daily to see if these things are so. This is the model for every Christian: test what you hear against the Bible.

At Athens, Paul is provoked by a city full of idols. He argues in the synagogue and the marketplace, and the philosophers bring him to the Areopagus. His speech is a model of cross-cultural preaching. He begins with their religiosity and the altar to an unknown god. Then he proclaims the God who made the world and everything in it, who does not live in temples made by man or need anything from human hands, and who gives to all mankind life and breath. He made from one man every nation, having determined their allotted periods and boundaries, that they should seek God. He quotes their own poets: “In him we live and move and have our being” and “We are his offspring.” Since we are God’s offspring, we ought not to think the divine being is like gold or silver or stone. The times of ignorance God overlooked, but now he commands all people everywhere to repent, because he has fixed a day to judge the world in righteousness by a man he has appointed, and has given assurance by raising him from the dead. Some mock at the resurrection, some want to hear more, and a few believe, including Dionysius and a woman named Damaris.

In Corinth, Paul meets Aquila and Priscilla, fellow tentmakers, and works with them. He preaches in the synagogue, and when the Jews oppose, he turns to the Gentiles. Crispus, the ruler of the synagogue, believes. The Lord appears to Paul in a night vision: “Do not be afraid, but go on speaking and do not be silent, for I am with you, and no one will attack you to harm you, for I have many in this city who are my people.” He stays a year and a half. At the end of the chapter, Apollos, an eloquent man mighty in the Scriptures, comes to Ephesus, and Priscilla and Aquila, hearing him, take him aside and explain the way of God more accurately. A husband and wife team the gifted teacher.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 44:9-20 mocks idols. Psalm 115:3-8 also. Deuteronomy 32:8 speaks of God setting the boundaries of nations. Isaiah 42:5 says God gives breath to the people. Romans 1:18-25 discusses the suppression of the truth. Romans 2:14-16 describes the law written on hearts. 1 Corinthians 2:1-5 shows Paul's approach at Corinth. 1 Corinthians 16:19 mentions Aquila and Priscilla. 2 Timothy 3:16-17 says all Scripture is God-breathed. Acts 24:15 speaks of the resurrection of the just and unjust.

STEP 6

Application

Be a Berean: check what you hear, including from me, against Scripture.

Learn to listen to the culture and find a bridge, like the altar, to speak of Christ.

Be like Priscilla and Aquila: take aside a gifted person who needs help and teach them.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Praise God as the one in whom we live and move and have our being.
- Ask him for the nobility of Berea, to examine Scripture daily.
- Pray for the people you know who worship the unknown.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 102

"Believe in the Lord Jesus, and you will be saved, you and your household."

ACTS 16:31

DAY 713 · WEEK 102

Acts 19:1-41

Ephesus, disciples receive the Spirit; the riot

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Reading · 41 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Acts 19:1-41. Paul spends nearly three years in Ephesus. Disciples of John receive the Spirit, extraordinary miracles occur, magic books are burned, and a riot breaks out over the goddess Artemis. Notice the power of the word.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Ephesus was the leading city of Asia Minor, home of the great temple of Artemis (Diana), one of the seven wonders of the ancient world. It was a center of magic and trade. Paul based his ministry here for about three years (AD 52 to 55), and the Ephesian church became one of the most important in the early church. From here, all of Asia heard the word of the Lord.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Did you receive the Holy Spirit when you believed?” (19:2).
2. “And when Paul had laid his hands on them, the Holy Spirit came on them, and they spoke in tongues and prophesied” (19:6).
3. “He withdrew from them and took the disciples with him, reasoning daily in the hall of Tyrannus” (19:9).
4. “Jesus I know, and Paul I recognize, but who are you?” (19:15).
5. “And a number of those who had practiced magic arts brought their books together and burned them in the sight of all” (19:19).
6. “So the word of the Lord continued to increase and prevail mightily” (19:20).
7. “Saying that gods made with hands are not gods” (19:26).
8. “Great is Artemis of the Ephesians!” (19:28).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul finds some disciples in Ephesus who knew only the baptism of John. When he asks, “Did you receive the Holy Spirit when you believed?” they have not even heard that there is a Holy Spirit. Paul explains that John’s baptism was a baptism of repentance, pointing to the one who would come after him, Jesus. They are baptized in the name of the Lord Jesus, and when Paul lays his hands on them, the Spirit comes. These were Old Testament believers who were brought into the new covenant era, a unique transitional moment, and not a pattern for later believers, since every Christian receives the Spirit at conversion (Romans 8:9).

Paul speaks boldly in the synagogue for three months, then moves to the hall of Tyrannus, where he reasons daily for two years, “so that all the residents of Asia heard the word of the Lord.” God does extraordinary miracles by the hands of Paul. Some Jewish exorcists try to use the name of Jesus as a formula, and the evil spirit answers, “Jesus I know, and Paul I recognize, but who are you?” The man overpowers them. The name of Jesus is not a magic word. It is a person, and only those who know him have authority in his name. The event brings fear, and the name of Jesus is extolled.

Many believers come, confessing and divulging their practices. A number of those who had practiced magic burn their books, valued at fifty thousand pieces of silver. “So the word of the Lord continued to increase and prevail mightily.” This is the evidence of real conversion: they gave up what was dear and profitable.

Then comes a riot. Demetrius, a silversmith, whose shrine-making trade is threatened, stirs up the craftsmen: “Not only in Ephesus but in almost all of Asia this Paul has persuaded and turned away a great many people, saying that gods made with hands are not gods.” The whole city is filled with confusion, and for two hours they shout, “Great is Artemis of the Ephesians!” The town clerk calms the crowd, pointing out that the Christians have neither robbed temples nor blasphemed their goddess, and that if Demetrius has a complaint, there are courts. He dismisses the assembly. Notice how Luke shows that the gospel is not a threat to public order, though it is a threat to idolatry and the economies that depend on it.

STEP 5

Connection

Matthew 3:11 records John’s promise of baptism with the Holy Spirit. Ephesians 1:13-14 says believers are sealed with the Spirit. The letter to the Ephesians and Revelation 2:1-7 address the same church. Deuteronomy 18:10-12 forbids sorcery. Psalm 115:4-8 mocks idols made by hands. 1 Corinthians 15:32 and 16:8-9 mention Paul’s time in Ephesus. 2 Timothy 1:15-18 mentions Onesiphorus. 1 John 5:21 says to keep yourselves from idols.

STEP 6

Application

Is there a “book” you need to burn, something from your old life that holds you?

Ask whether you know Jesus personally or just use his name.

Ask where the economics of idolatry affect your life, such as consumerism and entertainment.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to help you know Jesus rather than just use his name.
- Thank him for the Holy Spirit.
- Ask him to expose any idols in your life.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 102

“Believe in the Lord Jesus, and you will be saved, you and your household.”

ACTS 16:31

DAY 714 · WEEK 102

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Acts 16:31 slowly, several times, and say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Believe in the Lord Jesus, and you will be saved, you and your household."

ACTS 16:31

REST

Meditation

A Philippian jailer, trembling after an earthquake, asks Paul and Silas the most important question: "Sirs, what must I do to be saved?" This is their answer.

"Believe." To believe is more than agreeing with facts. It is to trust, to rely on, to put your weight on. The jailer is not told to do a task, but to trust a person.

"In the Lord Jesus." The object of faith is Jesus, the Lord who died and rose. He is the only Savior. "Lord" means the one who rules, and "Jesus" means the one who saves. To believe in him is to trust him as both.

"And you will be saved." The promise is certain. Not "might be" or "could be." Saved from sin, from judgment, and from death, and saved into life with God.

“You and your household.” The promise is for the jailer and extends to his family, who also heard the word and believed. It reminds us that God often works through families, and that faith in the head of a home opens the door to the gospel for the rest.

When you wonder what you must do to be saved or how to tell someone else, say this verse. It is the simplest summary of the gospel in the Bible.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you prayed Psalm 117, the shortest call to the nations. You followed the first journey to its end in Lystra and Derbe, where Paul was mistaken for a god and then stoned. At the Jerusalem Council, you saw the apostles decide that Gentiles are saved by grace, as Jews are, and you heard James cite Amos 9 about the rebuilding of David’s tent. You watched the second journey carry the gospel to Europe: Lydia’s heart was opened, and a jailer asked what he must do to be saved. You heard Paul preach to the Areopagus in Athens, you saw the Bereans search the Scriptures, and you spent three years in Ephesus, where the word prevailed mightily and magic books burned.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

The Jerusalem Council concluded that we are saved “through the grace of the Lord Jesus.” How do you tend to add to grace, and what would it mean to rest in it?

Lydia’s heart was opened by the Lord. Reflect on the moment God opened your heart. What did you notice then, and how has it changed you?

Paul preached differently to the Jews in Thessalonica and the philosophers in Athens. Who is your audience, and how might you meet them where they are while keeping the message of Christ the same?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Say with the jailer, “I believe in the Lord Jesus,” and mean it.

Pray for your household or those closest to you.

Rest in his grace.

DAY 715 · WEEK 103

Acts 20:1-38

Paul's farewell to the Ephesian elders

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Reading · 38 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Acts 20:1-38. Paul travels through Macedonia and Greece, raises Eutychus in Troas, and gives a farewell speech to the Ephesian elders at Miletus. Read the farewell slowly. It is Paul's pastoral testament.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Paul's third missionary journey is drawing to a close. He is headed for Jerusalem with a collection for the poor saints there, knowing that chains and afflictions await. On the way he meets the elders of the Ephesian church on a beach at Miletus. This is the only speech in Acts that Paul gives to believers rather than to unbelievers, and it reveals his heart for the church.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "On the first day of the week, when we were gathered together to break bread, Paul talked with them" (20:7).
2. "Testifying both to Jews and to Greeks of repentance toward God and of faith in our Lord Jesus Christ" (20:21).
3. "But I do not account my life of any value nor as precious to myself, if only I may finish my course and the ministry that I received from the Lord Jesus, to testify to the gospel of the grace of God" (20:24).
4. "For I did not shrink from declaring to you the whole counsel of God" (20:27).
5. "Pay careful attention to yourselves and to all the flock, in which the Holy Spirit has made you overseers, to care for the church of God, which he obtained with his own blood" (20:28).

6. “And now I commend you to God and to the word of his grace, which is able to build you up and to give you the inheritance among all those who are sanctified” (20:32).
7. “It is more blessed to give than to receive” (20:35).
8. “And there was much weeping on the part of all” (20:37).

STEP 4

Interpretation

At Troas, the church gathers on the first day of the week to break bread. Paul talks until midnight, and a young man, Eutychus, sitting in a window, falls asleep and falls three stories. He is taken up dead, and Paul embraces him and says, “Do not be alarmed, for his life is in him.” They go back upstairs, break bread, and talk until dawn. This verse is one of the clues that early Christians met on Sunday, the day of resurrection.

At Miletus, Paul summons the Ephesian elders and reminds them of how he lived among them. He served the Lord with all humility and with tears and trials. He did not shrink from declaring anything that was profitable, teaching in public and from house to house, testifying to both Jews and Greeks of repentance toward God and faith in the Lord Jesus. Now, he says, he is going to Jerusalem, bound in the Spirit, not knowing what will happen, except that the Holy Spirit testifies in every city that imprisonment and afflictions await him. “But I do not account my life of any value nor as precious to myself, if only I may finish my course and the ministry that I received from the Lord Jesus, to testify to the gospel of the grace of God.” He says they will not see his face again.

Then comes his charge: “Pay careful attention to yourselves and to all the flock, in which the Holy Spirit has made you overseers, to care for the church of God, which he obtained with his own blood.” The verse is rich: the Holy Spirit appoints pastors, the church belongs to God, and God bought it with his own blood, which is a striking reference to the cross. Paul warns that fierce wolves will come in, and even from among their own number men will arise speaking twisted things to draw away disciples. They must be alert. Within a few decades, the church of Ephesus had indeed faced such threats.

He commends them to God and to the word of his grace, “which is able to build you up.” The sufficiency of God’s word is the foundation of pastoral ministry. He reminds them of his example of working with his hands and quotes a saying of Jesus not found in the Gospels: “It is more blessed to give than to receive.” Then he kneels and prays with them, and they all weep and kiss him, sorrowing most of all because they will not see his face again.

STEP 5

Connection

Ezekiel 34 is a charge to shepherds. 1 Peter 5:1-4 is Peter's charge to elders. 1 Timothy 3:1-7 and Titus 1:5-9 give qualifications for overseers. 2 Timothy 4:1-8 is Paul's last charge to Timothy. Philippians 3:12-14 speaks of pressing on to finish the race. Ephesians 5:25 says Christ loved the church and gave himself for her. Hebrews 13:17 asks the church to submit to leaders who keep watch over souls. Revelation 2:1-7 is Christ's later word to Ephesus.

STEP 6

Application

Ask how you can finish your course with joy. What is the ministry the Lord has given you?

Pray for your pastors and elders by name this week. Thank them.

Give something away, a gift of time or money, and experience the blessing Jesus spoke of.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the church he bought with his own blood.

Ask him to teach you to declare his whole counsel.

Ask him to help you care for those he has put in your life.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 103

"But I do not account my life of any value nor as precious to myself, if only I may finish my course and the ministry that I received from the Lord Jesus, to testify to the gospel of the grace of God."

ACTS 20:24

DAY 716 · WEEK 103

Psalm 96

Sing to the LORD; declare his glory among the nations

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Psalm · 13 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 96. You met it earlier as the song David sang when the ark came to Jerusalem. Read it now as a missionary hymn: it calls God's people to declare his glory among the nations.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 96 is almost identical to the song in 1 Chronicles 16 that David appointed when the ark entered Jerusalem. In the Psalter, it begins a group of psalms (96 to 99) that celebrate the kingship of the LORD over the nations. Following Paul's farewell to the Ephesians, this psalm turns our attention outward again: the mission is not finished, and the church is called to declare his glory to all peoples.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Oh sing to the LORD a new song; sing to the LORD, all the earth!" (v. 1).
2. "Sing to the LORD, bless his name; tell of his salvation from day to day" (v. 2).
3. "Declare his glory among the nations, his marvelous works among all the peoples!" (v. 3).
4. "For great is the LORD, and greatly to be praised; he is to be feared above all gods" (v. 4).
5. "For all the gods of the peoples are worthless idols, but the LORD made the heavens" (v. 5).
6. "Worship the LORD in the splendor of holiness; tremble before him, all the earth!" (v. 9).
7. "Say among the nations, The LORD reigns!" (v. 10).

8 “For he comes, for he comes to judge the earth. He will judge the world in righteousness, and the peoples in his faithfulness” (v. 13).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm opens with a new song. The call is to the whole earth. The church has sung new songs in each generation, because each generation experiences God’s salvation afresh. “Tell of his salvation from day to day.” Day by day, the people of God are to speak of what he has done.

Then the center of the psalm: “Declare his glory among the nations, his marvelous works among all the peoples!” This is a missions command in the Psalms. Israel was a priestly kingdom, not only to keep the faith but to declare it to the world. Why? Because the LORD is great and greatly to be praised. The gods of the peoples are worthless idols, a word that sounds like “nothings,” but the LORD made the heavens. Idols cannot save. The nations need to know the living God.

Verses 7 to 9 call the families of the peoples to ascribe to the LORD glory and strength, to bring an offering and come into his courts. Worship is the right response of every nation. The splendor of holiness is the beauty of God’s character, before which all should tremble.

Verse 10 gives the message: “Say among the nations, The LORD reigns!” This is the gospel in the Old Testament. The reign of God is news. He has established the world; it shall never be moved. He will judge the peoples with equity. This is not a threat but good news to the oppressed. All creation joins in: the heavens are glad, the earth rejoices, the sea roars, the fields exult, and the trees of the forest sing for joy before the LORD, for he comes.

The psalm ends with the coming of the LORD to judge the earth in righteousness and in his faithfulness. For Christians, this coming is the return of Christ. We tell the nations of his salvation and his coming, and invite them to be reconciled to him before that day. The tone of the psalm is joy, because the coming judge is the same one who has saved.

STEP 5

Connection

1 Chronicles 16:23-33 gives the same song at the bringing of the ark. Psalm 67, 97, 98, and 99 are related psalms. Isaiah 42:10-12 also calls for a new song. Isaiah 52:7-10 proclaims the reign of God. Psalm 115:3-8 mocks idols. 1 Thessalonians 1:9 says they turned from idols to serve a living God. Revelation 5:9, 14:3, and 15:3-4 contain the new song. Matthew 28:18-20 is the Great Commission.

STEP 6

Application

Sing or read a hymn or song today that you have never used before. Make it a new song.

Tell someone of his salvation today. Say a sentence about what God has done for you.

Say verse 10 aloud, “The LORD reigns!” over a situation that troubles you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Sing to the LORD a new song, in your own words.

Tell someone of his salvation today, or ask him to help you.

Declare his glory among the nations.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 103

“But I do not account my life of any value nor as precious to myself, if only I may finish my course and the ministry that I received from the Lord Jesus, to testify to the gospel of the grace of God.”

ACTS 20:24

DAY 717 · WEEK 103

Psalm 98

The LORD has made known his salvation

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Psalm · 9 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 98. It is a joyful song about God's victory and salvation, revealed to the nations. Isaac Watts's hymn "Joy to the World" is based on this psalm.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 98 is a psalm without a title, but it builds on Psalm 96 and 97 and continues the theme of the LORD's kingship. It is filled with music: new songs, harps, trumpets, and the sea clapping. It is read at Christmas by many churches. In the context of Acts, it stresses that God has made his salvation known "in the sight of the nations."

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Oh sing to the LORD a new song, for he has done marvelous things!" (v. 1).
2. "His right hand and his holy arm have worked salvation for him" (v. 1).
3. "The LORD has made known his salvation; he has revealed his righteousness in the sight of the nations" (v. 2).
4. "He has remembered his steadfast love and faithfulness to the house of Israel" (v. 3).
5. "All the ends of the earth have seen the salvation of our God" (v. 3).
6. "Make a joyful noise to the LORD, all the earth; break forth into joyous song and sing praises!" (v. 4).
7. "Let the rivers clap their hands; let the hills sing for joy together" (v. 8).
8. "Before the LORD, for he comes to judge the earth. He will judge the world with righteousness, and the peoples with equity" (v. 9).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with the same call as Psalm 96, a new song, but gives a different reason: "for he has done marvelous things." Chief among these is salvation. "His right hand and his holy arm have worked salvation for him." The arm of the LORD is a picture of his strength to deliver, as in the exodus. Notice the phrase "for him": God's victory is not borrowed from anyone. He won it himself.

Verse 2 gives the missionary side: "The LORD has made known his salvation; he has revealed his righteousness in the sight of the nations." God's salvation is public. It is not hidden in a corner. And verse 3 shows how the two sides fit together: God remembered his steadfast love and faithfulness to the house of Israel. And as a result, all the ends of the earth have seen the salvation of our God. His covenant faithfulness to Israel is the way he brings salvation to the world. This is the story of Acts: the promises made to Israel are fulfilled in Jesus, and through him, the nations see the salvation of God. Simeon sang this when he held the child in the temple: "My eyes have seen your salvation… a light for revelation to the Gentiles."

Verses 4 to 6 call all the earth to make a joyful noise with lyre, trumpets, and the horn, before the King. And verses 7 to 9 extend the chorus to creation: the sea roars, the rivers clap their hands, and the hills sing for joy together, because the LORD is coming to judge the earth. Creation itself longs for the coming of the King (Romans 8:19-22). When he comes, creation will be set right.

Reading this psalm with Acts reminds us that the church's mission is accompanied by joy. We are not announcing a threat. We are announcing a victory. The right hand and the holy arm have worked salvation in the cross and the empty tomb, and the whole world is invited to see it and sing.

STEP 5

Connection

Exodus 15:1-18 is the original victory song. Isaiah 52:10 says all the ends of the earth shall see the salvation of our God. Isaiah 59:16 and 63:5 speak of his arm bringing salvation. Luke 2:30-32 is Simeon's song. Luke 1:68-75 is Zechariah's song. Romans 8:19-23 describes creation groaning and longing. Revelation 15:3-4 is the song of Moses and the Lamb. Isaac Watts's "Joy to the World" paraphrases this psalm.

STEP 6

Application

Sing "Joy to the World" aloud, even out of season.

Tell someone about a marvelous thing the LORD has done. Be specific.

Look at creation today, a tree or a hill or the sky, and imagine it singing to its Lord.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Sing to the LORD a new song for the marvelous things he has done.
- Thank him for making his salvation known.
- Ask him to help you break forth in joyous song.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 103

"But I do not account my life of any value nor as precious to myself, if only I may finish my course and the ministry that I received from the Lord Jesus, to testify to the gospel of the grace of God."

ACTS 20:24

DAY 718 · WEEK 103

Psalm 100

Make a joyful noise, all the earth

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Psalm · 5 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 100. You read it earlier in the Gospel of John. Read it now as the closing call of the missionary psalms: all the earth is invited to enter his gates with thanksgiving.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 100 completes a cluster of psalms (93 to 100) that celebrate the kingship of the LORD. It is the last and most compact of the invitations to all the earth. Having read psalms about declaring his glory and salvation to the nations, we come to the response: what the nations do when they come. They come to worship with gladness and gratitude.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Make a joyful noise to the LORD, all the earth!” (v. 1).
2. “Come into his presence with singing!” (v. 2).
3. “Know that the LORD, he is God!” (v. 3).
4. “It is he who made us, and we are his” (v. 3).
5. “We are his people, and the sheep of his pasture” (v. 3).
6. “Enter his gates with thanksgiving, and his courts with praise!” (v. 4).
7. “Give thanks to him; bless his name!” (v. 4).
8. “For the LORD is good; his steadfast love endures forever, and his faithfulness to all generations” (v. 5).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm opens with an invitation to "all the earth." The audience is the same as in Psalm 96 and 98. Here the focus is on the response of those who have heard the news and believed. They come with a joyful noise.

Verse 3 gives the basis for a right relationship: "Know that the LORD, he is God!" Knowing who God is comes first. The nations who once worshiped idols are now taught to know the LORD. "It is he who made us, and we are his." This is the confession of every convert. We belong to the one who made us. We are his people, the sheep of his pasture, the language of the shepherd. In Acts, the Gentiles who believe are included in this: "those who are far off" have been brought near (Ephesians 2:13), and they are now part of God's flock.

The call to enter his gates with thanksgiving shows the approach. We come to God not because we deserve it but with gratitude. Thanksgiving is the doorway. In Psalm 100, there is no sacrifice for sin mentioned, no priest, only joy. Under the new covenant, this joy rests on the finished sacrifice of Christ. We can enter the courts with praise because the way is open.

The final verse gives the threefold reason: the LORD is good (his character), his steadfast love endures forever (his covenant commitment), and his faithfulness extends to all generations (his reliability). Paul and the apostles saw this in action: the generations of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob, and David, and now the church. God has been faithful across the centuries, and he is faithful now.

Notice how the invitation and the response connect Acts to the Psalms. The command to the nations is the mission of the church. The response of the nations is the church's worship. In every city, from Antioch to Ephesus, new congregations were formed, singing, giving thanks, and calling on the name of the Lord. Psalm 100 is the picture of their gatherings.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 95 begins in a similar way. Psalm 117 is the shortest invitation to the nations. Ezekiel 34:30-31 calls Israel the flock of God. John 10:14-16 speaks of one flock, one shepherd. Ephesians 2:11-22 describes Gentiles brought near. Colossians 3:16-17 speaks of singing with thankfulness in your hearts. Hebrews 12:28 calls for acceptable worship with reverence and awe. Revelation 7:9-12 pictures the nations worshiping.

STEP 6

Application

Begin worship this week with thanksgiving. Enter his gates with a list of at least five things you are grateful for.

Read the psalm to someone who is new to the faith.

Thank God for the generations of faithful people who passed the gospel down to you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Make a joyful noise to the LORD, naming why.
- Thank him that he made you and you are his.
- Enter his presence with thanksgiving.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 103

"But I do not account my life of any value nor as precious to myself, if only I may finish my course and the ministry that I received from the Lord Jesus, to testify to the gospel of the grace of God."

ACTS 20:24

DAY 719 · WEEK 103

Acts 21:1-22:30

Paul arrested; his defense in the Temple

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Reading · 70 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Acts 21:1-22:30. Paul goes up to Jerusalem despite warnings, is seized in the temple, and gives his testimony from the steps of the barracks. Notice his courage, and how he retells his conversion.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Paul has finished his third journey and reaches Jerusalem around AD 57, with gifts for the poor believers. Prophets warn him in city after city that chains await. He goes anyway. In Jerusalem, rumors have spread that he teaches Jews to abandon Moses. The leaders suggest that he demonstrate his faithfulness by joining a vow in the temple. It leads to his arrest and the long imprisonment that takes him to Rome.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “What are you doing, weeping and breaking my heart? For I am ready not only to be imprisoned but even to die at Jerusalem for the name of the Lord Jesus” (21:13).
2. “And since he would not be persuaded, we ceased and said, Let the will of the Lord be done” (21:14).
3. “Men of Israel, help! This is the man who is teaching everyone everywhere against the people and the law and this place” (21:28).
4. “I am a Jew, from Tarsus in Cilicia, a citizen of no obscure city” (21:39).
5. “Brought up in this city, educated at the feet of Gamaliel according to the strict manner of the law of our fathers, being zealous for God as all of you are this day” (22:3).

6. “And I answered, Who are you, Lord? And he said to me, I am Jesus of Nazareth, whom you are persecuting” (22:8).
7. “And now why do you wait? Rise and be baptized and wash away your sins, calling on his name” (22:16).
8. “Go, for I will send you far away to the Gentiles” (22:21).

STEP 4

Interpretation

On the way, Paul and his companions stop in Tyre, where disciples urge him through the Spirit not to go to Jerusalem. In Caesarea, the prophet Agabus takes Paul’s belt, binds his own hands and feet, and says that the Jews at Jerusalem will bind the man who owns this belt. His friends beg him not to go. Paul replies with a moving statement: “What are you doing, weeping and breaking my heart? For I am ready not only to be imprisoned but even to die at Jerusalem for the name of the Lord Jesus.” When he would not be dissuaded, they said, “Let the will of the Lord be done.” He is not reckless. He is obedient.

In Jerusalem, James and the elders rejoice at the reports of the Gentiles. But they tell Paul that thousands of Jewish believers are zealous for the law and have heard that he teaches Jews to forsake Moses. They suggest he pay the expenses of four men under a vow. Paul agrees, an example of his flexibility (1 Corinthians 9:20). But Jews from Asia see him in the temple, seize him, and cry out that he has brought Greeks into the temple and defiled it. The whole city is stirred up. They drag him out and beat him, and he is rescued by the Roman tribune and his soldiers, who bind him with two chains.

As he is carried up the steps, Paul asks the tribune, in Greek, for permission to speak. The tribune is surprised. Paul addresses the crowd in Aramaic. He tells his story: a Jew born in Tarsus, trained under Gamaliel, zealous for God, who persecuted the Way to the death. On the Damascus road, he met the risen Jesus. Ananias said: “The God of our fathers appointed you to know his will, to see the Righteous One and to hear a voice from his mouth; for you will be a witness for him to everyone of what you have seen and heard. And now why do you wait? Rise and be baptized and wash your sins away, calling on his name.” Then Paul tells of a vision in the temple, where Jesus said, “Go, for I will send you far away to the Gentiles.”

At the word “Gentiles,” the crowd erupts, shouting, “Away with such a fellow from the earth!” The tribune orders him brought into the barracks to be examined by flogging. Paul asks the centurion, “Is it lawful for you to flog a man who is a Roman citizen and uncondemned?” The tribune becomes afraid. The next day he brings Paul before the council. Once again, Paul’s Roman citizenship protects him.

STEP 5

Connection

Acts 9:1-19 and 26:9-18 are the other accounts of his conversion. Galatians 1:13-16 gives his own testimony. Philippians 3:4-11 lists his Jewish credentials and counts them as loss. 1 Corinthians 9:19-23 describes his adaptability. Luke 9:51 shows Jesus setting his face toward Jerusalem. Romans 15:25-31 is Paul's request for prayer about the trip. 2 Corinthians 11:23-28 lists his sufferings. Matthew 26:39 is Jesus' prayer, "Not as I will, but as you will."

STEP 6

Application

Practice telling your own story of how you met Jesus in two minutes.

Ask whether there is a step of obedience you have avoided because of fear.

Pray "Let the will of the Lord be done" for a situation you cannot control.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to give you courage to obey even when it costs you.

Thank Jesus for setting his face toward Jerusalem.

Ask him to make you a witness in your setting.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 103

"But I do not account my life of any value nor as precious to myself, if only I may finish my course and the ministry that I received from the Lord Jesus, to testify to the gospel of the grace of God."

ACTS 20:24

DAY 720 · WEEK 103

Acts 23:1-24:27

Before the Sanhedrin and Felix

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Reading · 62 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Acts 23:1-24:27. Paul appears before the Sanhedrin, the Lord encourages him, a plot is foiled, and he is brought to Caesarea to stand before Governor Felix. Notice Paul's conscience and the center of his defense: the resurrection.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Paul is in Roman custody, and the tribune brings him before the Jewish council to find out what he is accused of. Here and in the following hearings, Paul consistently turns the discussion to the hope of the resurrection. A plot of more than forty men to kill him is uncovered by his nephew, and he is moved by night to Caesarea, the Roman capital, where he is held under Governor Felix for two years.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Brothers, I have lived my life before God in all good conscience up to this day" (23:1).
2. "Brothers, I am a Pharisee, a son of Pharisees. It is with respect to the hope and the resurrection of the dead that I am on trial" (23:6).
3. "The following night the Lord stood by him and said, Take courage, for as you have testified to the facts about me in Jerusalem, so you must testify also in Rome" (23:11).
4. "According to the Way, which they call a sect, I worship the God of our fathers, believing everything that is laid down by the Law and written in the Prophets" (24:14).
5. "Having a hope in God, which these men themselves accept, that there will be a resurrection of both the just and the unjust" (24:15).
6. "So I always take pains to have a clear conscience toward both God and man" (24:16).

7. “And as he reasoned about righteousness and self-control and future judgment, Felix was alarmed and said, Go away for the present. When I get an opportunity I will summon you” (24:25).

8. “Felix left Paul in prison” (24:27).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Before the council, Paul begins, “Brothers, I have lived my life before God in all good conscience up to this day.” The high priest Ananias orders him struck on the mouth. Paul says, “God is going to strike you, you whitewashed wall!” When told that he is speaking to the high priest, Paul apologizes, acknowledging the law: “You shall not speak evil of a ruler of your people.” Even apostles had sharp moments.

Then Paul realizes the council is divided between Sadducees and Pharisees. He cries out, “Brothers, I am a Pharisee, a son of Pharisees. It is with respect to the hope and the resurrection of the dead that I am on trial.” The council erupts in dispute. Some argue that they find nothing wrong with the man. The tribune, fearing Paul will be torn to pieces, takes him back to the barracks. That night, “the Lord stood by him and said, Take courage, for as you have testified to the facts about me in Jerusalem, so you must testify also in Rome.” This is a vital promise. Whatever happens, Paul will reach Rome.

A plot is hatched: more than forty men take an oath neither to eat nor drink until they have killed Paul. Paul’s nephew hears of it and warns the tribune, who sends Paul under heavy guard (two hundred soldiers, seventy horsemen, two hundred spearmen) to Governor Felix in Caesarea. God uses the Roman army to protect his apostle.

Five days later, the high priest and a lawyer named Tertullus arrive and accuse Paul. Paul’s defense is calm and clear. He had not stirred up a crowd; he came to Jerusalem to bring alms. “According to the Way, which they call a sect, I worship the God of our fathers, believing everything that is laid down by the Law and written in the Prophets.” The Christian faith is not a new religion but the fulfillment of Israel’s hope. His hope is the resurrection of both the just and the unjust. “So I always take pains to have a clear conscience toward both God and man.”

Felix, who knows more about the Way than most, puts off a decision. Later, he and his wife Drusilla hear Paul speak about faith in Christ Jesus. As Paul reasons about righteousness, self-control, and future judgment, Felix becomes alarmed and sends him away. He hopes for a bribe and sends for Paul often, but nothing changes. After two years, Felix is succeeded by Festus, and desiring to do the Jews a favor, he leaves Paul in prison. Felix is a warning: he heard the truth, was alarmed, and put it off.

STEP 5

Connection

Exodus 22:28 is the law Paul cites about speaking evil of rulers. Daniel 12:2 speaks of the resurrection of the just and the unjust. Luke 20:27-38 records Jesus on the resurrection against the Sadducees. Acts 4:1-2 and 17:32 show the resurrection as a point of dispute. 1 Corinthians 15 is Paul's great chapter on the resurrection. 2 Corinthians 1:12 mentions a clear conscience. 1 Timothy 1:5 and 1:19 speak of a good conscience. Proverbs 27:1 warns against boasting about tomorrow. Hebrews 3:15 says today, if you hear his voice, do not harden your hearts.

STEP 6

Application

Ask whether your conscience is clear before God and man. If not, confess and make it right.

Do you put off a conviction because the timing is not convenient? Respond today.

Take courage from the Lord's word to Paul. He stands by you too.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for standing by Paul, and ask him to stand by you.
- Ask him for a clear conscience before him.
- Tell him what you fear.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 103

"But I do not account my life of any value nor as precious to myself, if only I may finish my course and the ministry that I received from the Lord Jesus, to testify to the gospel of the grace of God."

ACTS 20:24

DAY 721 · WEEK 103

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Acts 20:24 slowly, several times, and say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"But I do not account my life of any value nor as precious to myself, if only I may finish my course and the ministry that I received from the Lord Jesus, to testify to the gospel of the grace of God."

ACTS 20:24

REST

Meditation

Paul says this to the Ephesian elders on the beach at Miletus, knowing that he is going to Jerusalem and that chains and afflictions await.

"I do not account my life of any value nor as precious to myself." Paul is not careless about his life. He knows its worth, but he does not hold it as the highest good. For him, life is a trust, to be spent for something greater.

"If only I may finish my course." He pictures his life as a race to finish. A course has a beginning and an end, and the goal is to complete it. In his last letter, Paul writes that he has fought the good fight, finished the race, and kept the faith.

"And the ministry that I received from the Lord Jesus." The task is not Paul's invention. It is received, given by the Lord Jesus himself. Each of us also receives a calling.

“To testify to the gospel of the grace of God.” This is the center of Paul’s ministry. Not his own cleverness, but the good news of grace: that sinners are saved freely by God’s favor in Christ.

When you are afraid of the cost of faithfulness, say this verse. The goal is not to protect our lives but to finish the course and testify to the grace of God.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you saw Paul on the road: a full Jerusalem Council behind him and the ministry in Ephesus finished. You read his tender farewell to the Ephesian elders, with its charge to shepherd the church of God, which he obtained with his own blood. Three psalms sang the mission: Psalm 96, declare his glory among the nations; Psalm 98, all the ends of the earth have seen the salvation of our God; and Psalm 100, enter his gates with thanksgiving. Then Paul went up to Jerusalem, knowing what awaited him. You watched him seized in the temple, retell his conversion on the steps, stand before the council and Felix, and speak of the hope of the resurrection. The Lord told him, “Take courage… you must testify also in Rome.”

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Paul said he did not count his life as precious if only he could finish his course. What is one thing in your life that you are holding too tightly, and what would it look like to hold it more loosely for the sake of Christ?

Paul told the elders to care for the church “which he obtained with his own blood.” How does that change the way you think about your own church and its people?

Felix heard the truth, was alarmed, and put it off. Is there a truth God is pressing on you that you’ve been postponing? What is one step you can take today?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for the church he bought with his blood.

Ask him to help you finish your course.

Rest in him.

DAY 722 · WEEK 104

Acts 25:1-26:32

Before Festus and Agrippa, "I stand on trial for hope"

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Reading · 50 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Acts 25:1-26:32. Paul appeals to Caesar, and then makes his defense before King Agrippa. His third account of his conversion ends with an appeal. Read 26:12-29 slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Felix is succeeded by Festus, who immediately faces the Jewish leaders' demand to bring Paul to Jerusalem, where they plan an ambush. Paul, as a Roman citizen, exercises his right to appeal to Caesar. Before sending him to Rome, Festus consults King Agrippa II, who is familiar with Jewish customs. The hearing is an opportunity for Paul to give a full account of the gospel before the political and military leaders of the region.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I appeal to Caesar" (25:11).
2. "And now I stand here on trial because of my hope in the promise made by God to our fathers" (26:6).
3. "Why is it thought incredible by any of you that God raises the dead?" (26:8).
4. "To open their eyes, so that they may turn from darkness to light and from the power of Satan to God, that they may receive forgiveness of sins and a place among those who are sanctified by faith in me" (26:18).
5. "Therefore, O King Agrippa, I was not disobedient to the vision from heaven" (26:19).
6. "To this day I have had the help that comes from God, and so I stand here testifying both to small and great, saying nothing but what the prophets and Moses said would come to pass" (26:22).

7. “In a short time would you persuade me to be a Christian?” (26:28).
8. “Whether short or long, I would to God that not only you but also all who hear me this day might become such as I am, except for these chains” (26:29).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Festus tells the Jews that Roman custom does not condemn a man before he has met his accusers face to face. At Caesarea, they bring many serious charges that they cannot prove. Festus, wishing to do the Jews a favor, asks Paul whether he is willing to go to Jerusalem for trial. Paul knows what would happen. “I appeal to Caesar.” This appeal, within a Roman citizen’s rights, takes the case to Rome and fulfills the Lord’s promise in 23:11.

When King Agrippa and his sister Bernice arrive, Festus explains his dilemma: he has no clear charge to write to the emperor. Agrippa asks to hear Paul. Paul says he considers himself fortunate to defend himself before one so familiar with Jewish customs. He tells his story: his strict Pharisaic upbringing, his persecution of the saints, and his encounter on the Damascus road. He now reports the commission with its fullest wording. Jesus said he was sending Paul “to open their eyes, so that they may turn from darkness to light and from the power of Satan to God, that they may receive forgiveness of sins and a place among those who are sanctified by faith in me.” This is a summary of the gospel: darkness to light, Satan’s power to God, forgiveness and an inheritance, by faith in Christ.

Paul says, “I was not disobedient to the vision from heaven.” He declared to Jews and Gentiles that they should repent and turn to God, performing deeds in keeping with their repentance. For this, the Jews seized him. And yet he says, “I stand here testifying both to small and great, saying nothing but what the prophets and Moses said would come to pass: that the Christ must suffer and, by being the first to rise from the dead, would proclaim light both to our people and to the Gentiles.”

Festus interrupts: “Paul, you are out of your mind; your great learning is driving you out of your mind.” Paul replies, “I am not out of my mind, most excellent Festus, but I am speaking the sober truth.” Then he turns to Agrippa: “King Agrippa, do you believe the prophets? I know that you believe.” Agrippa says, “In a short time would you persuade me to be a Christian?” Paul’s reply is full of grace: “Whether short or long, I would to God that not only you but also all who hear me this day might become such as I am, except for these chains.” Agrippa concludes that Paul could have been set free if he had not appealed to Caesar. But the appeal is God’s means of bringing him to Rome.

STEP 5

Connection

Acts 9:1-19 and 22:1-21 are the other accounts of the conversion. Isaiah 42:6-7 and 49:6 speak of opening blind eyes and being a light to the Gentiles. Isaiah 53 and Psalm 22 speak of the Christ's suffering. 1 Corinthians 15:3-8 summarizes the gospel as Paul received it. Colossians 1:12-14 echoes the language of 26:18. 2 Timothy 4:16-18 mentions the Lord standing by him at his first defense. Philippians 1:12-14 says his imprisonment advanced the gospel. Romans 13:1-7 teaches about the state.

STEP 6

Application

Memorize Acts 26:18 as a summary of what conversion means.

Ask yourself Paul's question to Agrippa: do you believe the prophets?

Think of someone who is "almost persuaded." Pray for them as Paul did.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for opening your eyes and turning you from darkness to light.
- Ask him to give you a clear testimony.
- Pray for someone who is hardened against him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 104

"For I am not ashamed of the gospel, for it is the power of God for salvation to everyone who believes, to the Jew first and also to the Greek."

ROMANS 1:16

DAY 723 · WEEK 104

Acts 27:1-28:31

The voyage; the shipwreck; Rome

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Reading · 60 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Acts 27:1-28:31. Paul sails for Rome, endures a storm and a shipwreck, survives a snakebite on Malta, and arrives in the capital. The book ends with Paul under house arrest, preaching the kingdom of God. Notice how Acts ends: without a conclusion, because the story continues.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Paul is sent to Rome as a prisoner under the centurion Julius, along with Luke and Aristarchus. It is late in the sailing season and dangerous. Luke's account of the voyage is among the most detailed ancient descriptions of a sea journey. Beyond its drama, the voyage shows God's faithfulness in carrying out the promise made in 23:11: Paul will testify in Rome.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "When neither sun nor stars appeared for many days, and no small tempest lay on us, all hope of our being saved was at last abandoned" (27:20).
2. "Do not be afraid, Paul; you must stand before Caesar" (27:24).
3. "So take heart, men, for I have faith in God that it will be exactly as I have been told" (27:25).
4. "And so it was that all were brought safely to land" (27:44).
5. "And the brothers there, when they heard about us, came as far as the Forum of Appius and Three Taverns to meet us. On seeing them, Paul thanked God and took courage" (28:15).

6. “From morning till evening he expounded to them, testifying to the kingdom of God and trying to convince them about Jesus both from the Law of Moses and from the Prophets” (28:23).

7. “Therefore let it be known to you that this salvation of God has been sent to the Gentiles; they will listen” (28:28).

8. “Proclaiming the kingdom of God and teaching about the Lord Jesus Christ with all boldness and without hindrance” (28:31).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The voyage begins in good weather but deteriorates. Paul warns that the journey will be dangerous, but the centurion trusts the pilot and the owner of the ship. A violent northeaster, the “Euraquilo,” seizes the ship. For days they are driven, throwing cargo and tackle overboard. “All hope of our being saved was at last abandoned.” Then Paul stands up: an angel of God had stood by him that night and said, “Do not be afraid, Paul; you must stand before Caesar. And behold, God has granted you all those who sail with you.” “So take heart, men, for I have faith in God that it will be exactly as I have been told.” The prisoner becomes the leader of the ship. When sailors try to escape in the lifeboat, Paul warns the centurion. On the fourteenth night, Paul urges them all to eat, takes bread, gives thanks to God in the presence of all, and breaks it. Two hundred seventy-six people are on board. The ship runs aground, and the soldiers plan to kill the prisoners, but the centurion, wishing to save Paul, stops them. All reach land safely, some swimming and some on pieces of the ship.

On Malta, the islanders show unusual kindness. A viper fastens on Paul’s hand, and the people expect him to die; when he shakes it off and suffers no harm, they say he is a god. This is a reversal of Lystra, where they first worshiped and then stoned him. Paul heals the father of the chief man of the island, and the rest of the sick come and are cured. After three months, they sail again for Rome.

Believers meet Paul at the Forum of Appius and Three Taverns, “and on seeing them, Paul thanked God and took courage.” In Rome, he is allowed to live by himself with a soldier guarding him. Three days later, he calls the local Jewish leaders and explains why he is in chains: “it is because of the hope of Israel.” They arrange a day, and many come to his lodging. “From morning till evening he expounded to them, testifying to the kingdom of God and trying to convince them about Jesus both from the Law of Moses and from the Prophets.” Some are convinced, others disbelieve. Paul quotes Isaiah 6 about hardened hearts and says, “This salvation of God has been sent to the Gentiles; they will listen.”

The book ends abruptly: “He lived there two whole years at his own expense, and welcomed all who came to him, proclaiming the kingdom of God and teaching about the Lord Jesus Christ with all boldness and without hindrance.” Luke does not tell us what happened to Paul at the trial. The ending is deliberate: the word of God is not bound (2 Timothy 2:9). The story of the church continues in every generation, including yours. From Jerusalem to Rome, from the upper room to the center of the empire, the gospel has gone out.

STEP 5

Connection

Acts 1:8 is the program that is fulfilled here. Psalm 107:23-30 describes sailors rescued from a storm. Jonah 1 is another storm at sea. Isaiah 6:9-10 is the quotation about hardened hearts. Romans 1:8-15 and 15:22-29 reveal Paul’s longing to see Rome. Philippians 1:12-14, Ephesians 6:19-20, Colossians 4:3, and Philemon are letters from this imprisonment. 2 Timothy 4:6-8 is his final testimony. Ephesians 2:19-22 describes the household of God.

STEP 6

Application

Review your own storms. Was God keeping a promise that you couldn’t see?

Read Acts 1:8 again and see how the book has fulfilled it. Where are you in the story?

Take the closing words as a charge: proclaim the kingdom and teach about Jesus with all boldness.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for the book of Acts and the word spreading to the ends of the earth.
- Thank him for his faithfulness through storms.
- Ask him to keep you bold and unhindered.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 104

“For I am not ashamed of the gospel, for it is the power of God for salvation to everyone who believes, to the Jew first and also to the Greek.”

ROMANS 1:16

DAY 724 · WEEK 104

Review and Reflection

Unit 19 review, The New Covenant Applied, Acts

Year 2 · Unit 19 · Review

MEMORY

Unit Verse

> "But you will receive power when the Holy Spirit has come upon you, and you will be my witnesses in Jerusalem and in all Judea and Samaria, and to the end of the earth."
>
> ACTS 1:8

REST

Meditation

Jesus speaks these words to his disciples just before he ascends. They are his last words in Acts, and they set the agenda for the rest of the book and the church age.

"But you will receive power." Jesus does not ask the disciples to do the work in their own strength. They will receive power. The power is not for show, but for witness.

"When the Holy Spirit has come upon you." The source of the power is the Holy Spirit, poured out at Pentecost. Without him there is no true witness. With him, ordinary people become bold.

"And you will be my witnesses." A witness tells what he has seen and heard. The disciples had seen the risen Jesus. We have the testimony of Scripture and our own experience of grace. We too can tell what we know.

"In Jerusalem and in all Judea and Samaria." The witness begins at home, in your city, then reaches the surrounding region and the despised outsiders. Each of us has a Jerusalem, a Judea, and a Samaria.

"And to the end of the earth." There is no limit. The gospel is for every nation, and the church is called to carry it there.

When you feel inadequate to share the gospel, say this verse. The power is his, and the promise is for you.

LOOK BACK

Unit Recap

You have read the book of Acts, the story of the risen Christ continuing his work by the Holy Spirit through his church. It began with the ascension, when Jesus promised power to witness in Jerusalem, Judea, Samaria, and the ends of the earth. In four doctrinal pauses, you studied Christ's ascension and reign, the person and work of the Holy Spirit, repentance, and the means of grace. At Pentecost, the Spirit was poured out on all flesh, fulfilling Joel, Ezekiel, and Jeremiah, and Peter preached that God had made Jesus both Lord and Christ. The church devoted itself to the apostles' teaching, fellowship, the breaking of bread, and prayer. Despite arrests, the death of Stephen, and persecution, the word of God increased. It moved to Samaria, to an Ethiopian official, and to Cornelius, the first Gentile convert, when God showed Peter that no one is common or unclean. Saul, the persecutor, met the risen Christ and became Paul, the apostle to the Gentiles. The church at Antioch sent Barnabas and Paul on the first journey, the Jerusalem Council affirmed that Gentiles are saved by grace through faith, and the second and third journeys planted churches in Philippi, Thessalonica, Athens, Corinth, and Ephesus, in line with the Abrahamic promise that all families of the earth would be blessed. Paul's farewell to the Ephesian elders charged them to shepherd the church of God, and he went up to Jerusalem, was arrested, defended himself before Felix, Festus, and Agrippa, and was brought through storm and shipwreck to Rome, where he preached the kingdom of God with all boldness and without hindrance. The Psalms accompanied the story: Psalms 2, 16, and 110 for the exalted Christ, and Psalms 67, 87, 117, 96, 98, and 100 for the nations.

REFLECT

Review Questions

How does Pentecost fulfill the promises of Joel, Ezekiel, and Jeremiah?

Read Joel 2:28-32, Ezekiel 36:26-27, Jeremiah 31:33-34, and Acts 2:14-21. What did these prophets promise about the Spirit and the new covenant, and what do you see in Acts 2 that matches?

What does the Jerusalem Council decide?

Reread Acts 15:1-35. What was the question, how did Peter and James reason, and what was the result? Why does this matter for the gospel of grace?

How does Paul's missionary strategy reflect the Abrahamic promise?

Think about Genesis 12:3 and Acts 13:47. Notice where Paul went first, how the Gentiles responded, and how he planted churches with elders. How does this show that the promise to bless all nations was being fulfilled?

What does Acts teach us about the nature of the church?

Look at Acts 2:42-47 and 20:28. What are the marks of a healthy church? What does it mean that the church belongs to God, who obtained it with his own blood?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the Spirit who empowers witnesses.

Thank him for how the gospel has reached you.

Ask him to keep the unit verse before you.